LESSON HANDOUT

Module: Know the Question Stems – RC

Lesson 3.5.1: Inference-Closed Questions – 1

WHERE WE ARE

Module 3 has moved through global question types — main idea, primary purpose, title — and has built a thorough understanding of local closed questions. By now, you know what a specific pointer in the stem looks like, you know how to locate the relevant passage section, you know how to anticipate the answer before going to the options, and you know how to kill wrong options using the STEALS framework.

This lesson introduces Inference-Closed questions — a category that sounds very different but, as you are about to discover, is almost entirely the same thing in disguise. The word inference tends to create a particular kind of anxiety. Students read it and immediately shift into a different mode, imagining something buried deep in the passage requiring elaborate deductive steps. They feel that the rules they have learnt no longer apply.

This lesson exists to correct that. Its single most important claim is this: in CAT, the word 'inferred' almost always means 'true.' Once you really believe that — not just hear it, but internalise it — the way you approach these questions changes completely. The context also matters: IIM Indore, which set CAT 2020, is expected to conduct CAT 2026 as well. Their inference questions are predictable in construction. This lesson maps them.

IDENTIFYING AN INFERENCE-CLOSED QUESTION

Two features must both be present for a question to count as Inference-Closed.

Feature 01 — Explicit Inference Marker

The stem contains words like: infer, inferred, implies, implied, suggests, supported by, can be concluded from. These are the setter's signals that the question is asking for something beyond simple fact-retrieval.

Feature 02 — Specific Pointer

The stem anchors you to a particular part of the passage — a person, a study, a concept, a paragraph, a phrase, a claim. This is what makes it closed rather than open. You are not asked to draw a general conclusion from the full passage. You are told exactly where to look.

Both features together give you an Inference-Closed question. In terms of frequency: across the CAT question bank, inference-closed questions account for 62 out of approximately 100 inference questions — roughly 14% of all RC questions. These are not occasional. They are consistent and significant, and IIM Indore's construction patterns are highly predictable.

WHAT DOES 'INFER' ACTUALLY MEAN IN CAT?

This is the lesson's central question — and the answer might feel underwhelming at first. That underwhelm is the lesson.

In formal logic, an inference requires a multi-premise chain: you take two or more given facts and derive a third that was not explicitly stated. Something like: all of Gejo's students are serious; some of Gejo's students are currently weak in RC; therefore, some serious students are currently weak in RC. That is a real logical deduction. How often does CAT ask for that kind of inference? Roughly 3% of the time.

So what is the correct answer in the remaining 97% of cases? One of two things.

63% — Paraphrased Truth

The same content from the passage, restated in different words. The question setter has used the word 'inferred' in a way that is frankly misleading — because paraphrasing is not inferring. But that is the reality. No inferential step is required.

34% — Implied Truth

One small logical step beyond what is stated. The passage says A is greater than B. The correct answer says B is less than A. One step, no more. Implied truths come in three sub-shapes: Connect Two Parts (combine two stated facts from different paragraphs); Decode a Device (translate a metaphor or rhetorical question into its literal meaning); Apply a Principle (use a stated rule on a specific case — by similarity, contrast, or counterfactual).

The practical consequence: in CAT, 'inferred' means 'true.' An Inference-Closed question should be treated using exactly the same method as a Local-Closed question. Same doodle. Same anticipation. Same STEALS-based elimination. Nothing changes.

DISTORTION PROFILE — WHAT WRONG OPTIONS LOOK LIKE

Across wrong options in Inference-Closed questions, tagged using STEALS, the distribution is: Alien 37%, Sidetrack 33% (Twist 18.5% + Truth 14.5%), Lie 21%, Scope 4.5%, Tone 3%, Extreme 1.5%.

The dominant pattern: wrong options are most often alien ideas, twisted versions of real passage content, or true statements that do not answer the question. This is essentially the same profile as local closed questions — further confirmation that the two question types should be approached identically. Watch especially for Alien Ideas (concepts not present anywhere in the passage) and Sidetrack Twists (real passage words used to make a claim the passage never authorises).

THE PASSAGE

Source: *"Travel Writing, Geography and..." · Encyclopedia of Human Geography*

Stats: 515 words | 23 sentences | 22.4 avg. words per sentence | Flesch–Kincaid Grade: 16.7
Reading Difficulty: Grade 16.7 — graduate-level prose. Academic register. Heavy nominal phrases. Don't try to fully decode every clause — extract the move each paragraph is making and keep going.

¶1 Mode of transportation affects the travel experience and thus can produce new types of travel writing and perhaps even new "identities." Modes of transportation determine the types and duration of social encounters; affect the organization and passage of space and time; . . . and also affect perception and knowledge — how and what the traveler comes to know and write about. The completion of the first U.S. transcontinental highway during the 1920s . . . for example, inaugurated a new genre of travel literature about the United States — the automotive or road narrative. Such narratives highlight the experiences of mostly male protagonists "discovering themselves" on their journeys, emphasizing the independence of road travel and the value of rural folk traditions.

¶2 Travel writing's relationship to empire building — as a type of "colonialist discourse" — has drawn the most attention from academicians. Close connections have been observed between European (and American) political, economic, and administrative goals for the colonies and their manifestations in the cultural practice of writing travel books. Travel writers' descriptions of foreign places have been analyzed as attempts to validate, promote, or challenge the ideologies and practices of colonial or imperial domination and expansion. Mary Louise Pratt's study of the genres and conventions of 18th- and 19th-century exploration narratives about South America and Africa (e.g., the "monarch of all I survey" trope) offered ways of thinking about travel writing as embedded within relations of power between metropole and periphery, as did Edward Said's theories of representation and cultural imperialism. Particularly Said's book, Orientalism, helped scholars understand ways in which representations of people in travel texts were intimately bound up with notions of self, in this case, that the Occident defined itself through essentialist, ethnocentric, and racist representations of the Orient. Said's work became a model for demonstrating cultural forms of imperialism in travel texts, showing how the political, economic, or administrative fact of dominance relies on legitimating discourses such as those articulated through travel writing. . . .

¶3 Feminist geographers' studies of travel writing challenge the masculinist history of geography by questioning who and what are relevant subjects of geographic study and, indeed, what counts as geographic knowledge itself. Such questions are worked through ideological constructs that posit men as explorers and women as travelers — or, conversely, men as travelers and women as tied to the home. Studies of Victorian women who were professional travel writers, tourists, wives of colonial administrators, and other (mostly) elite women who wrote narratives about their experiences abroad during the 19th century have been particularly revealing. From a "liberal" feminist perspective, travel presented one means toward female liberation for middle- and upper-class Victorian women. Many studies from the 1970s onward demonstrated the ways in which women's gendered identities were negotiated differently "at home" than they were "away," thereby showing women's self-development through travel. The more recent poststructural turn in studies of Victorian travel writing has focused attention on women's diverse and fragmented identities as they narrated their travel experiences, emphasizing women's sense of themselves as women in new locations, but only as they worked through their ties to nation, class, whiteness, and colonial and imperial power structures.

READING THE PASSAGE — PARAGRAPH BY PARAGRAPH

The passage is a dense academic essay from the Encyclopedia of Human Geography — not an opinion piece but a scholarly survey of how travel writing has been theorised across three distinct analytical lenses. Reading it well means tracking the move each paragraph makes, not decoding every clause.

Paragraph 1 — Mode of Transport Shapes Writing and Identity.

The paragraph opens with a direct causal claim: mode of transportation affects the travel experience and thus produces new forms of travel writing and even new identities. The 1920s transcontinental highway created a new genre — the road narrative — whose content tells you exactly what these new identities looked like: mostly male protagonists, self-discovery on the road, independence, and an appreciation for rural folk tradition. The author is observing and illustrating, not evaluating.

Doodle: *Mode of transport shapes travel writing AND identity. 1920s road narrative — male, self-discovering.*

Paragraph 2 — Travel Writing as Colonial Discourse.

The paragraph pivots to a different lens — travel writing as an instrument of colonial power. The connection: European and American colonial ambitions found expression in travel writing. Descriptions of foreign places were tools to validate, promote, or challenge colonial ideologies. Pratt's work showed travel writing as embedded within relations of power between metropole and periphery. Said's Orientalism showed how representations in travel texts were tied to self-definition — the West constructed its identity by representing the East through essentialist and racist lenses. Said's work became the model for showing how dominance relies on legitimating cultural discourses.

Doodle: *Travel writing = colonial discourse. Pratt + Said: legitimised dominance.*

Paragraph 3 — Feminist Geography's Two Lenses.

A third perspective: feminist geography challenges the male-dominated and colonial-centred history that Paragraphs 1 and 2 describe. The challenge is methodological — feminist geographers question who and what counts as a subject of geographic study. Two internal perspectives are distinguished. The liberal feminist view saw travel as liberatory for Victorian women — particularly middle- and upper-class women who negotiated identities differently when away from home. The poststructural view is more complex: women's multiple and fragmented identities can only be understood through positions within nation, class, whiteness, and colonial power. Liberation itself was partial and conditioned.

Doodle: *Feminist scholars: 2 lenses. Liberal — travel = liberation, identity at home vs away. Poststructural — diverse, fragmented identities.*

THE QUESTIONS

Question 1 · *Inference-Closed · Not-Stem (Find the Distortion)*

From the passage, we can infer that feminist scholars' understanding of the experiences of Victorian women travellers is influenced by all of the following EXCEPT scholars':

(1) awareness of the ways in which identity is formed.

(2) perspective that they bring to their research.

(3) knowledge of class tensions in Victorian society.

(4) awareness of gender issues in Victorian society.

Correct Answer: (3)

Type: Inference-Closed · Not-Stem. Three options are genuine influences on feminist scholarship. One is not supported by the passage. Find the option that has no home in the passage.

The Demand

This is a Not-Stem question. Three options are truths. One is the distortion. The subject is: what influenced feminist scholars' understanding of Victorian women travellers? Go to Paragraph 3. That is where feminist scholarship lives.

Anticipate

Paragraph 3 mentions: identity formation, scholarly perspectives (liberal vs poststructural), gender identity, women's negotiation of identity at home versus away, women's ties to nation, class, whiteness, and colonial power. Three of the four options should trace directly back to these elements. The fourth will introduce something not present — or will twist something real. Look specifically at the word class — it appears in the passage, but class tensions does not.

Kill the Options

(1) awareness of the ways in which identity is formed.

Tag: True — Eliminate.
The entire thrust of Paragraph 3 is about identity — how it is formed, how it is negotiated differently at home versus away, how it is fragmented across multiple structures. Feminist scholars are clearly working with a deep awareness of how identity operates. Supported. Eliminate.

(2) perspective that they bring to their research.

Tag: True — Eliminate.
Paragraph 3 distinguishes two scholarly perspectives — liberal feminist and poststructural. Different perspectives produce different readings of the same material. Scholars' perspectives visibly shape their conclusions. Supported. Eliminate.

(3) knowledge of class tensions in Victorian society.

Tag: S — Sidetrack (Twist). This is your answer.
The word 'class' is real — Paragraph 3 says women's identities were shaped by their ties to 'nation, class, whiteness, and colonial and imperial power structures.' Class is mentioned as a structural position, a background condition that shapes identity. It is not described as a site of conflict or struggle. There is no discussion of class tensions — no friction between classes, no class antagonism. The option has taken a real word from the passage and added a concept from outside it. That move — using authentic passage language to dress up an alien idea — is the classic Sidetrack Twist. Do not fall for it.

(4) awareness of gender issues in Victorian society.

Tag: True — Eliminate.
Paragraph 3 is entirely about gender: who counts as a geographic subject, how women's gendered identities were negotiated, how ideology constructs men and women differently. Feminist scholars are explicitly aware of gender issues. Supported. Eliminate.

Question 2 • *Inference-Closed · Apply-a-Principle (Find the Closest Analogy)*

From the passage, we can infer that travel writing is most similar to:

(1) political journalism.
(2) historical fiction.
(3) autobiographical writing.
(4) feminist writing.

Correct Answer: (3)

Type: Inference-Closed · Apply-a-Principle. Take the passage's characterisation of travel writing and find the writing form that shares its fundamental quality. No narrow pointer — you need the full passage's portrait.

The Demand

What does travel writing fundamentally do, according to this passage? Once you have the answer, find the option that shares that quality. This is an Apply-a-Principle Implied Truth. The principle is stated across all three paragraphs. The task is to identify the best instance of it.

Anticipate

Paragraph 1: travellers discover themselves and write about that discovery. Paragraph 2: travel writing constructs the self through representations of others — the Occident defines itself. Paragraph 3: women's identities are formed and narrated through travel. Across all three paragraphs, travel writing is about the writer making meaning out of their own experience, shaping and revealing identity. What kind of writing shares that? Writing about the self. Writing where experience becomes narrative identity.

Kill the Options

(1) political journalism.

Tag: A — Alien Idea.
Politics is referenced in Paragraph 2, but political journalism is reporting on external political events. Travel writing, as the passage characterises it, is experiential narrative that produces identity and meaning — not external reporting. The overlap is only superficial. Eliminate.

(2) historical fiction.

Tag: A — Alien Idea.
Historical fiction is invented narrative set in a historical period. Travel writing, as the passage presents it, is a record of actual experience. The passage does not connect travel writing to fictionalised storytelling anywhere. Eliminate.

(3) autobiographical writing.

Tag: Correct Answer.
Autobiographical writing is writing about one's own lived experience — the self made narrative. That is exactly what the passage describes travel writing as doing across all three paragraphs. In Paragraph 1, travellers discover themselves and write about that discovery. In Paragraph 2, the Occident defines itself through its representations of the East. In Paragraph 3, women's gendered identities are formed and narrated through travel. In every case, the writing is fundamentally about the experience of the self as it moves through the world. Every word is earned.

(4) feminist writing.

Tag: S — Sidetrack (Truth that does not answer the question).
Paragraph 3 discusses feminist geographical scholarship on travel writing — but feminist writing is the analytical category used to study travel texts, not a form of writing that travel writing resembles. The option collapses the distinction between the object of study and the framework of study. Classic confusion between subject and lens. Eliminate.

Question 3 · *Inference-Closed · Causation-Anchored (Find the Truth)*

From the passage, it can be inferred that scholars argue that Victorian women experienced self-development through their travels because:

(1) their identity was redefined when they were away from home.

(2) they were from the progressive middle- and upper-classes of society.

(3) they were on a quest to discover their diverse identities.

(4) they developed a feminist perspective of the world.

Correct Answer: (1)

Type: Inference-Closed · Causation-Anchored. The word 'because' is doing the structural work. Find the passage's explanation for why travel led to self-development. Hunt for the word 'self-development' in the passage first.

The Demand

The question asks for the cause of Victorian women's self-development through travel — according to scholars. Go and hunt for 'self-development' in the passage. It is a precise term. Find it, read the surrounding sentence carefully, and the answer will be right there.

Relevant Information

Paragraph 3: 'Many studies from the 1970s onward demonstrated the ways in which women's gendered identities were negotiated differently "at home" than they were "away," thereby showing women's self-development through travel.' The 'thereby' signals causation. The cause is the differential negotiation of identity — the difference between who you were at home and who you became away.

Anticipate

The correct answer should say something about identity being different, renegotiated, or transformed when away from home. It should reflect the home-versus-away logic and be a paraphrase of the passage sentence, not an addition to it.

Kill the Options

(1) their identity was redefined when they were away from home.

Tag: Correct Answer. Paraphrased Truth.
'Identities were negotiated differently at home than they were away' becomes 'identity was redefined when they were away from home.' Negotiated differently away from home = redefined when away from home. The content is identical. The words are different. Every word is earned.

(2) they were from the progressive middle- and upper-classes of society.

Tag: S — Sidetrack (Truth that does not answer the question).
Paragraph 3 does mention middle- and upper-class Victorian women — they are described as the group for whom travel was a means toward liberation. So this is true information. But it describes who these women were, not why self-development happened. The question asks for the cause. Class background is a context, not an explanation. Do not confuse 'who' with 'why.'

(3) they were on a quest to discover their diverse identities.

Tag: S — Sidetrack (Twisted Version).
This option is dangerous because both key words — 'discover' and 'diverse identities' — are genuinely in the passage. But they have been stitched together in a way the passage never does. 'Discovering themselves' appears in Paragraph 1 for male road narratives of the 1920s — not Victorian women. 'Diverse and fragmented identities' appears in the poststructural section of Paragraph 3 as a description of how scholars analysed the narratives — not as a goal the women themselves were pursuing. The notion of a 'quest' — a deliberate, intentional search — is completely invented. Classic Sidetrack Twist.

(4) they developed a feminist perspective of the world.

Tag: S — Sidetrack (Twisted Version).
Paragraph 3 uses 'liberal feminist perspective' — but it describes the analytical framework that researchers brought to these studies, not a perspective that Victorian women themselves developed. The feminist perspective belongs to the geographers studying those narratives from the 1970s onward. The option has collapsed the distinction between subject and analyst, assigning the analyst's lens to the subject.

LOCAL-CLOSED QUESTIONS — CONTRAST SET

These two questions do not carry inference markers. They are standard local closed questions — detail retrieval from a specific part of the passage. They are included here so you can see the comparison directly: how similar the method is, and how much the word 'infer' was doing in the first three questions to create a false sense of elevated difficulty.

Question 4 • *Local-Closed · Detail-Retrieval*

American travel literature of the 1920s:

(1) celebrated the freedom that travel gives.

(2) developed the male protagonists' desire for independence.

(3) presented travellers' discovery of their identity as different from others.

(4) showed participation in local traditions.

Correct Answer: (1)

Type: Local-Closed · Detail-Retrieval. Specific pointer: American travel literature of the 1920s. Go to Paragraph 1.

The Demand

Go to the end of Paragraph 1. Relevant sentence: 'Such narratives highlight the experiences of mostly male protagonists "discovering themselves" on their journeys, emphasizing the independence of road travel and the value of rural folk traditions.'

Anticipate

The content is about self-discovery, independence of road travel, and valuing rural folk traditions. Your correct answer will be a faithful version of one of these. Watch for word-level distortions — the setter has been precise with this option set.

Kill the Options

(1) celebrated the freedom that travel gives.

Tag: Correct Answer. Paraphrased Truth.
The passage says narratives emphasised 'the independence of road travel.' Independence of road travel = the freedom that travel gives. Same idea in different words. Clean paraphrase. Correct.

(2) developed the male protagonists' desire for independence.

Tag: S — Sidetrack (Twist). 'Desire for independence' is not what the passage says.
The word 'independence' is genuinely in the passage. But the passage says narratives emphasised the independence of road travel — meaning the travel itself was autonomous. The option converts this into a claim that the travel developed a desire for independence in the protagonists. That is a causal and psychological claim the passage never makes. One real word. One invented idea. Sidetrack Twist.

(3) presented travellers' discovery of their identity as different from others.

Tag: S — Sidetrack (Twist). 'Different from others' is invented.
The passage says protagonists were 'discovering themselves.' The option says they were discovering their identity 'as different from others.' That added phrase is not in the passage. Self-discovery is not the same as discovering a distinctive identity that sets you apart from other people. The addition is alien. The core word is real. Classic Twist.

(4) showed participation in local traditions.

Tag: S — Sidetrack (Twist). 'Participation' distorts 'value of rural folk traditions.'
The passage says narratives emphasised 'the value of rural folk traditions.' Valued — not participated in. Valuing something and participating in it are different things. The option substitutes an active verb for a passive one, misrepresenting the relationship between the traveller and the tradition.

Question 5 • *Local-Closed · Detail-Retrieval*

According to the passage, Said's book, Orientalism:

(1) explained the difference between the representation of people and the actual fact.

(2) demonstrated how cultural imperialism was used to justify colonial domination.

(3) argued that cultural imperialism was more significant than colonial domination.

(4) illustrated how narrow-minded and racist westerners were.

Correct Answer: (2)

Type: Local-Closed · Detail-Retrieval. Specific pointer: Said's book, Orientalism. Go to Paragraph 2. The question asks what the book did, not what Orientalism as a concept means.

The Demand

Relevant lines from Paragraph 2: 'Said's work became a model for demonstrating cultural forms of imperialism in travel texts, showing how the political, economic, or administrative fact of dominance relies on legitimating discourses such as those articulated through travel writing.'

Anticipate

What did Orientalism do? It demonstrated how cultural imperialism in travel texts was used to legitimise political and administrative dominance. The correct answer should say something very close to this.

Kill the Options

(1) explained the difference between the representation of people and the actual fact.

Tag: A — Alien Idea.

The passage says representations of people in travel texts were 'intimately bound up with notions of self' — not that Said explained the gap between representation and reality. The option introduces a comparison — representation versus actual fact — that the passage never makes. Alien idea.

(2) demonstrated how cultural imperialism was used to justify colonial domination.

Tag: Correct Answer. Paraphrased Truth.

The passage says Said's work became 'a model for demonstrating cultural forms of imperialism in travel texts, showing how the political, economic, or administrative fact of dominance relies on legitimating discourses.' Dominance relies on legitimating discourses = cultural imperialism was used to justify colonial domination. The correspondence is direct. Every word is earned.

(3) argued that cultural imperialism was more significant than colonial domination.

Tag: S — Sidetrack (Twist). The passage connects them — it does not rank them.

The passage says cultural imperialism and colonial domination are connected — one legitimates the other. The option converts this connection into a comparison of significance. The passage never makes that ranking. The word 'more significant' has been invented to turn a relationship into a hierarchy. Sidetrack Twist.

(4) illustrated how narrow-minded and racist westerners were.

Tag: T — Tone Mismatch. The passage's language is analytical; this option reduces it to a moral verdict.

The passage uses 'essentialist, ethnocentric, and racist' as analytical descriptors for the kind of representations the Occident produced. Said's argument is a scholarly theoretical one about how self-definition works through the construction of otherness. The option reduces this to a moral character judgement about westerners. The tone is wrong. The register is wrong. Eliminate.

OVERALL LEARNING

Five questions. Three inference-closed. Two local-closed for contrast. One method. What this lesson has shown you is that the label 'inference' changes nothing about how you solve the question. You still doodle, you still name the demand, you still anticipate, you still take options to the doodle, you still verify when uncertain. The STEALS tags are the same. The discipline is the same.

The central learning: in CAT, 'inferred' means 'true.' 63% of inference questions give you paraphrased truth. 34% give you implied truth — one small step beyond stated content. Only 3% require anything resembling real logical deduction. When you see the word 'infer' in a stem, note it, acknowledge it, and then proceed exactly as you would with a local closed question.

What the inference label does is create a psychological shift — the sense that now you must dig deeper, now the rules are different. That shift is the trap. Students who fall into it start reaching beyond the passage, entertaining possibilities the text does not support, evaluating options by how logically sophisticated they sound rather than how faithfully they reflect what the passage said. That is where marks get lost.

Watch especially for Alien Ideas — 37% of wrong options in this type — which sound credible, use the academic register of the passage, but introduce concepts the passage simply did not contain. Watch equally for Sidetrack Twists — 18.5% — which use real passage vocabulary to make claims the passage never authorises. A real word plus an invented connection. A genuine phrase plus a distorted implication. Slow down. Ask: is the idea itself supported, or only the individual words?

Questions 4 and 5 in this lesson were local closed questions — and they were at least as difficult as the inference questions, if not more so. That is the point. The difficulty of a question is not in the label of its stem. It is in the precision of the options. The method that handles local closed questions well handles inference closed questions well. Carry this into every question set you attempt from here.

LESSON HANDOUT

Module: Know the Question Stems – RC

Lesson 3.5.2: Inference-Closed Questions – 2

WHERE WE ARE

The previous lesson established the core framework for Inference-Closed questions. Two markers confirm the type: an inference word in the stem — infer, implied, suggests, conclude — and a specific anchor that points you to a defined region of the passage. Both are present, the type is confirmed, and the method is fixed: go to the anchor, read the region, take one small step. Do not aim higher than the passage allows.

That method does not change in this lesson. What changes are the costumes. An Inference-Closed question does not always hand you its anchor in the same way. Sometimes the anchor is a quoted line from the passage. Sometimes it is the names of two people whose shared view is being tested. Sometimes it is a phrase from the text whose meaning you are being asked to unpack. Sometimes it is a number or statistic from which you are asked to draw a conclusion. Four shapes. One type. One method.

This lesson drills all four on a single passage — an accessible piece of journalistic prose from The Economist on emigration, remittances, and the Kerala model of growth. The reading is not difficult. The thinking is. The passage builds two contrasting cases — India and Kerala — to make a structural argument about the economics of emigration. Your job is to hold that argument clearly enough to answer four questions of four different shapes without being pulled in the wrong direction by options that look dangerously close to the truth.

THE FOUR SHAPES OF INFERENCE-CLOSED

The two-marker test from the previous lesson is your primary tool. When you see an inference word and a specific anchor together in the same question stem, the type is Inference-Closed and your technique is settled. What you now need to recognise is that the anchor can arrive in four different forms.

Shape 1 — A Quoted Line

"Much of Kerala's remittance windfall is spent on building houses and buying cars..." From this statement we can infer that the author believes that:

Here the anchor is a direct quotation from the passage. The question lifts a sentence from the text and places it in front of you. Your job is to read what that sentence actually says, hold the idea, and find the option that captures it without distorting it. The trap in this shape is that the quotation itself can lull you into thinking the answer must be close to the surface — and then the options arrive with careful alterations. The quoted words feel familiar. The shifts in meaning are quiet.

Shape 2 — A Shared View

A valid inference can be made from the passage that Charles & Khanna would both agree that:

Here the anchor is not one location but two — two people whose positions you must locate separately and then compare. The question is asking for a claim that both would support. That means the correct option cannot rely on anything that only one of them says. If one scholar discusses diaspora size and the other does not, any option built around diaspora size fails the shared-view test. You need a claim grounded in both their stated positions.

Shape 3 — A Phrase Reference

It can be inferred that the "effects of Iran war" points to:

Here the anchor is a specific phrase from the passage. The question is asking what that phrase is doing in the argument — what it points to, what it represents, what its function is within the broader logic of the paragraph. You need to go back to the exact location of that phrase and read it in context. What surrounds it? What argument is it supporting? The phrase is not free-floating; it is doing a specific job, and your answer must reflect that job, not some adjacent truth the phrase happens to sit near.

Shape 4 — A Numeric Claim

"India's IT exports are now worth more than $220bn annually, more than the $135bn the country earns in total from remittances." Which of the following is a valid conclusion that can be drawn from this statement?

Here the anchor is a data point — a comparison of two numbers. The conclusion must follow from the comparison itself. The numbers tell you one thing: one figure is larger than the other. The context of the passage helps you interpret what those figures represent, but the conclusion must be constrained by what the comparison actually says. Do not let the surrounding paragraphs push you into a conclusion the numbers alone do not support.

Four shapes. Same anchor-and-infer structure. Same technique: locate the home, read the region, take one small step, and stop.

THE PASSAGE

Source: *"Can countries grow richer by exporting people, not goods?" · The Economist*

514 words · 30 sentences · Avg. 17.1 words/sentence · Flesch-Kincaid Grade 11.1 · Accessible journalistic prose

¶1 Most of the oil in Kerala is pressed from coconuts. Yet the southern Indian state, famed for idyllic backwaters, fragrant cuisine and an easy-going lifestyle, owes much of its prosperity to barrels of the foul-smelling crude that comes bubbling out of the ground in the Persian Gulf. . . . Ever since the Middle East oil boom began half a century ago Keralites have been heading there to work, first as cleaners and construction workers, then as clerks, nurses and salespeople. An estimated 1.7 million of them live in the Gulf, equal to 5% of the state's population and close to 11% of its workforce. Gulf oil money has transformed Kerala. . . . Remittances from the region were equivalent to about a quarter of the state's output, and more than both its value added in manufacturing and its public spending. . . . Consumption per person is nearly three-quarters above the Indian average. . . . Could exporting people rather than goods, as Kerala does, provide an alternative path to prosperity? . . .

¶2 Charles Kenny of the Centre for Global Development, a think-tank in Washington, finds virtually no relationship between the size of a country's diaspora and its growth in GDP per person. . . . Mr Kenny still believes emigrants can, in some circumstances, be an economic stimulant. Everything depends on the nature of emigration's spillover effects. These can be positive if they raise average human capital in the sending country and this is harnessed domestically. They can also perpetuate the very problems that lead people to leave. . . .

¶3 Gaurav Khanna of the University of California, San Diego, examines the waves of Asian migration to America. Some of these, Mr Khanna argues, have facilitated "brain circulation" rather than "brain drain". Lots of Indians, for example, have earned software-engineering degrees in the hope of seizing lucrative opportunities in Silicon Valley. Some won the migration lottery and headed to San Francisco, but many more stayed behind. That created a new export industry, able to be delivered not only in person, through migration, but remotely from places like Bangalore, in Karnataka state. India's IT exports are now worth more than $220bn annually, more than the $135bn the country earns in total from remittances.

¶4 In Kerala, by contrast, the spillovers look meagre. . . . Would-be investors are put off by. . .anti-capitalist economic policies and the state's overweening trade unions. . . . Businesses struggle to match wage expectations hoisted high by labour-market links to deep-pocketed employers in the Gulf. As a result, companies prefer to set up shop in business-friendlier places like Tamil Nadu next door. Much of Kerala's remittance windfall is spent on building houses and buying cars, which raises living standards but not productivity. . . .

¶5 Perhaps the biggest drawback of emigration-led growth is that its success rests on factors beyond the sending country's control. . . . The number of Keralites in the Gulf has plateaued in recent years as countries there reserve certain jobs for citizens. Their remittances could decline by 20% this year as the knock-on effects of the Iran war hurt the region's economies. Emigration nearly always benefits emigrants and their families back home. Banking on it for broader growth amid rising fragmentation, protectionism and conflict is perilous.

READING THE PASSAGE — PARAGRAPH BY PARAGRAPH

Before a single question is attempted, the passage must be read and mapped. This is the doodle — not a luxury, not optional. Five paragraphs, five key ideas. Build the map first.

Paragraph 1 — Kerala's prosperity built on Gulf remittances

The opening paragraph sets the subject with a deliberate contrast. Kerala is presented as a state of coconut oil, backwaters, and relaxed living — and yet its real economic engine is something else entirely: crude oil pulled from the Gulf and sent back as remittances. The numbers are striking. 1.7 million Keralites in the Gulf; remittances equivalent to a quarter of the state's output; consumption per person nearly three-quarters above the Indian average. The paragraph ends on a question — the passage's central question — which reframes this extraordinary situation as a replicable model. Could exporting people rather than goods provide an alternative path to prosperity? Everything that follows is the answer.

Doodle: *Kerala — 1.7 million in the Gulf → remittances ≈ ¼ of state output → prosperity. But is this replicable? Big question.*

Paragraph 2 — Emigration helps only if domestic spillovers are positive

Charles Kenny arrives here with a deliberately unsatisfying finding: there is virtually no relationship between the size of a country's diaspora and its GDP growth per person. That sounds damning for the emigration model — but Kenny does not stop there. He still believes emigration can be a stimulant in some circumstances. The key phrase is "spillover effects." Emigration can help if it raises human capital in the sending country and that human capital is then harnessed domestically. It can also do the opposite — perpetuating the very conditions that drove people to leave in the first place. The paragraph does not resolve this tension. It maps it.

Doodle: *Kenny: diaspora size ≠ GDP growth. BUT emigration can stimulate — IF spillovers raise domestic human capital. Depends.*

Paragraph 3 — Brain circulation built India's domestic export industry

Gaurav Khanna's work offers the positive case. He examines Asian migration to America and identifies a pattern he calls "brain circulation" rather than "brain drain." The mechanism is important. Indians pursued software-engineering degrees hoping to reach Silicon Valley. Some got there. Many more did not — and stayed in India. That pool of trained, aspirant engineers who remained behind became the workforce for a new domestic export industry. Bangalore happened not because of migration but because of the skills developed in anticipation of possible migration. The figures at the end of the paragraph make the point sharply: India's IT exports now exceed $220bn annually, more than the $135bn earned in total from remittances. The people who stayed built more value than the people who left.

Doodle: *Khanna: brain circulation (not brain drain). India — aspiration → skills → stayed behind → IT industry. $220bn IT > $135bn remittances.*

Paragraph 4 — Kerala's spillovers are meagre: consumption, not productivity

Paragraph 4 opens with "by contrast" — and that contrast is the structural heart of the passage. India worked. Kerala did not. The author identifies several reasons. Anti-capitalist economic policies and strong trade unions deter investors. Wage expectations are inflated by the high salaries available in the Gulf, making local businesses uncompetitive — and so companies go to Tamil Nadu instead. And crucially: Kerala's remittance windfall goes into building houses and buying cars. Living standards go up. Productivity does not. The money is real. Its economic effect is shallow.

Doodle: *Kerala: by contrast — spillovers meagre. Policies + unions deter investors. Remittances → houses + cars → living standards, NOT productivity.*

Paragraph 5 — Emigration-led growth is fragile and externally dependent

The final paragraph steps back from the India-Kerala comparison to make the author's broader argument. The biggest drawback of emigration-led growth is structural: its success rests on factors the sending country cannot control. The Gulf has plateaued as a destination for Keralites — host countries are now reserving jobs for citizens. Remittances could fall 20% because of a war in Iran — a shock originating entirely outside Kerala's control. Emigration almost always benefits emigrants and their families individually. But banking on it for national growth is perilous when the global environment is increasingly fragmented, protectionist, and conflict-prone. The conclusion is not that emigration is bad — it is that it is fragile as a development strategy.

Doodle: *Biggest drawback: success depends on factors OUTSIDE sending country's control. Gulf plateauing + Iran war → fragile. Banking on emigration for growth — perilous.*

QUESTIONS AND EXPLANATIONS

Four questions. All Inference-Closed. Each in a different shape.

Question 1 Shape 1 — A Quoted Line

"Much of Kerala's remittance windfall is spent on building houses and buying cars..."
From this statement we can infer that the author believes that:

(1) the spending pattern seen in Kerala has actively lowered productivity levels across the state's wider economy.
(2) Kerala's remittance money is not being directed into channels that would strengthen the state's economic foundation.
(3) the spending pattern in Kerala is the reason business opportunities are now flowing to other states instead.
(4) Keralites have chosen consumption over investment because of an affinity for living standards over productivity.

Correct Answer: (2)

Type

Inference-Closed · Shape 1 (A Quoted Line)

The Demand

The question has quoted a specific line from Paragraph 4 and asked what the author infers from it. This is a Shape 1 question — the anchor is handed to you directly. Your job is not to wonder where to look; you are already standing at the right line. The demand is: what is the one-step read-off from this quoted sentence?

The quoted line says: remittances are spent on building houses and buying cars, which raises living standards but not productivity. That "but not productivity" is the hinge. The author is saying that the money is going somewhere, and that somewhere is not productive capacity. The inference cannot go further than that. It cannot assign blame, establish causation with other factors, or attribute motivation to Keralites.

Relevant Passage Logic

Paragraph 4 makes a layered argument. Several reasons are given for Kerala's meagre spillovers: anti-capitalist policies, strong trade unions, wage inflation. The quoted sentence arrives at the end of that list. It is one observation within a broader diagnosis, not the single cause of everything. The sentence says the money raises living standards. It says it does not raise productivity. That is all it says.

Anticipate

The correct option should restate the quoted sentence without overstating it. It should capture the idea that the money is not going where it would generate productive growth. It should not introduce causal claims the sentence does not make, attribute motivation to Keralites, or connect the spending to other outcomes that were caused by other factors mentioned elsewhere in the paragraph.

Option (1) — Wrong

This option says the spending pattern "has actively lowered productivity levels across the state's wider economy." Read the sentence again. It says the spending raises living standards but not productivity. It does not say productivity has been lowered. There is a significant difference between not raising productivity and actively lowering it. More importantly, this option constructs a causal claim — the spending pattern caused the productivity decline — which the quoted sentence does not support. The productivity problem in Kerala has multiple identified causes in Paragraph 4: investor deterrence, wage inflation, policy environment. The spending on houses and cars is one element in that picture, not the driver of the whole decline. This is a sidetrack — a false causal connection between two real elements of the passage.

Option (2) — Correct

This is the answer. "Not being directed into channels that would strengthen the state's economic foundation" is a clean paraphrase of "raises living standards but not productivity." The money exists. It is going somewhere. But that somewhere is not productive investment. "Economic foundation" maps onto productivity and long-term growth. The tone is right — the author is not blaming; he is observing. The option does not claim the spending caused something else. It does not go beyond the sentence. Every word is earned.

Option (3) — Wrong

This option says the spending pattern is "the reason business opportunities are now flowing to other states instead." That is not what the quoted sentence says. The reason companies move to Tamil Nadu is explained separately — anti-capitalist policies, trade unions, wage expectations inflated by Gulf standards. The spending on houses and cars is not given as the reason for business flight. This is a sidetrack that takes two real elements from Paragraph 4 and constructs a causal link between them that the passage never establishes. Watch for this kind of option: it lifts real content — spending pattern, businesses moving elsewhere — and connects them with a "is the reason" the text never supports.

Option (4) — Wrong

This option says Keralites "have chosen consumption over investment because of an affinity for living standards over productivity." Two problems. First: the quoted sentence does not describe a choice. It observes where the money goes — it does not say Keralites made a deliberate decision based on a preference. Second: "affinity for living standards over productivity" imports a motivation and attitude the passage never attributes to Keralites. The author is neutral and analytical; he is not making a character claim about a state's population. This goes beyond the passage by a significant margin. It is alien in the specific dimension of motivation — the passage has no psychological explanation for the spending pattern.

Question 2 Shape 2 — A Shared View

A valid inference can be made from the passage that Charles & Khanna would both agree that:

(1) the size of a country's diaspora has no real bearing on the economic growth that the sending country experiences over time.

(2) emigration creates real economic value for sending countries only when migrants eventually return home with new skills and capital.

(3) emigration is not inherently a drain on the sending country, and its impact depends on how it interacts with the domestic economy.

(4) brain circulation between developed and developing nations is a reliable way for sending countries to build new export industries.

Correct Answer: (3)

Type

Inference-Closed · Shape 2 (A Shared View)

The Demand

This is the shared-view shape. Two named people are given — Charles Kenny and Gaurav Khanna — and you need an inference that both would endorse. This means you have two anchors, not one: Paragraph 2 for Kenny and Paragraph 3 for Khanna. The correct option must be grounded in what both of them actually say. If an option relies on a claim that only one of them makes, it fails the test immediately, regardless of how accurate it is about that one person.

The shared-view shape is a test of your passage map. If you read the passage without tracking who says what, this question becomes dangerous. If you doodled properly, you know where each scholar lives and what their core claim is.

Relevant Passage Logic

Kenny's position: diaspora size does not determine GDP growth per person. But emigration can still be a stimulant in some circumstances. Everything depends on the spillover effects — whether they raise domestic human capital and whether that capital is harnessed locally. Emigration is not automatically good or bad; it is conditional.

Khanna's position: some waves of Asian migration facilitated brain circulation rather than brain drain. In India's case, the aspiration of moving abroad built a skilled workforce that stayed and became an export industry. The outcome was domestically harnessed. The key mechanism: interaction with the domestic economy determined the outcome.

The overlap between the two: emigration is not inherently a drain. Its effect depends on how it interacts with domestic conditions.

Anticipate

The shared claim should be something neutral and conditional — emigration can be either good or bad depending on what happens at home. Both scholars are saying this in different ways. Neither is a simple optimist or pessimist about emigration. Both acknowledge conditionality.

Option (1) — Wrong

This is Kenny's claim, not Khanna's. Kenny finds virtually no relationship between diaspora size and GDP growth. Khanna's work does not address diaspora size at all — he is focused on the mechanism of brain circulation and the creation of domestic industries. There is no basis in Paragraph 3 for attributing a view on diaspora size to Khanna. This option fails the shared-view test cleanly: it is a single-scholar claim presented as a joint one.

Option (2) — Wrong

This option says emigration creates economic value "only when migrants eventually return home." Nobody in the passage says that. Neither Kenny nor Khanna argues for return migration as the mechanism. Kenny's condition for positive spillovers is that human capital is raised and harnessed domestically — that does not require physical return. Khanna's India case involves people who did not go to Silicon Valley, not people who went and came back. "Return home" is a concept the passage never introduces. This is an alien idea — it sounds plausible as an emigration-economics claim but has no basis in either scholar's stated position.

Option (3) — Correct

This is the answer. Unpacked: emigration is not inherently a drain — Kenny says it can be a stimulant, and Khanna shows it can produce brain circulation rather than brain drain. Its impact depends on how it interacts with the domestic economy — Kenny says everything depends on spillover effects and how human capital is harnessed domestically; Khanna shows that India's interaction with global aspiration created a domestic industry. Both positions land on the same structural claim. The option is careful: "not inherently" rather than "never a drain" is the right level of precision. "Depends on how it interacts with the domestic economy" is a clean synthesis of both scholars' conditional logic.

Option (4) — Wrong

Brain circulation is Khanna's concept — Kenny never uses it and it is not part of his argument. Worse, "reliable way" goes further than even Khanna claims. Khanna observes that in some waves of Asian migration, brain circulation happened and an export industry resulted. He is not saying this is a reliable formula that sending countries can replicate. And Kenny certainly does not say this — his whole paragraph is about conditionality and the risk that emigration perpetuates problems. "Reliable" is an extreme claim that neither scholar supports, and "brain circulation" is a concept belonging to only one of them.

Question 3 Shape 3 — A Phrase Reference

It can be inferred that the "effects of Iran war" points to:

(1) the rising fragmentation and protectionism in the global economy that makes emigration-led growth a perilous strategy in the long run.

(2) the dependence of Kerala's remittance flows on the political and economic stability of the Persian Gulf region in particular.

(3) one of the reasons Gulf countries are now reserving certain categories of jobs for their own citizens instead of foreign workers.

(4) the kind of external shock that exposes the fragility of an economic model built on factors that lie outside a state's control.

Correct Answer: (4)

Type

Inference-Closed · Shape 3 (A Phrase Reference)

The Demand

The anchor here is a specific phrase — "effects of Iran war" — and the question is asking what it points to within the argument. This is not a question about what the Iran war is in the real world. It is a question about the function of this phrase within Paragraph 5. What job is this phrase doing in the author's argument? What does it represent in the logic of the passage?

To answer correctly, you need to go back to the exact sentence in Paragraph 5 where the phrase appears and read what surrounds it. The phrase is not free; it is embedded in a specific argument structure, and its meaning is determined by that structure.

Relevant Passage Logic

The sentence reads: "Their remittances could decline by 20% this year as the knock-on effects of the Iran war hurt the region's economies." This is one of two examples given in support of the paragraph's opening claim: "the biggest drawback of emigration-led growth is that its success rests on factors beyond the sending country's control." The first example is Gulf countries reserving jobs for citizens — a structural, ongoing shift. The Iran war is the second example — a sudden external shock happening now, in this year, that could cut remittances by 20%.

The Iran war is being used as an illustration of what external, uncontrollable shocks look like. It is not about protectionism or fragmentation — those are different concepts from the final sentence. It is not about the political stability of the Gulf in general — that is too broad. It is not about why Gulf countries reserve jobs — that is a different cause. It is an example of the kind of unexpected, externally-sourced disruption that the entire paragraph is warning against.

Anticipate

The correct option should describe the Iran war reference as an example of an external shock — something that happens outside Kerala's control and exposes the fragility of a remittance-dependent model. It should be specific enough to reflect what the phrase is actually doing in the argument, not what the broader paragraph is about.

Option (1) — Wrong

This option links the Iran war to "rising fragmentation and protectionism in the global economy." That is real passage content — it appears in the final sentence of Paragraph 5 — but it is not what the Iran war phrase points to. The Iran war is a specific event used as an example of external shock; fragmentation and protectionism are separate, broader structural forces listed in a different sentence. The question is asking specifically about the Iran war reference, not about the paragraph's concluding sweep. This is a sidetrack that takes genuine passage content from a nearby sentence and attaches it to the wrong phrase.

Option (2) — Wrong

This option says the Iran war reference points to Kerala's dependence on the political and economic stability of the Persian Gulf. The dependence on the Gulf is a genuine and important idea in the passage — but the Iran war phrase is being used to illustrate what disruption to that dependence looks like, not to establish the dependence itself. More precisely, this option broadens the reference too much. The Iran war is a specific kind of event — an external shock — not a general description of political instability. The passage uses it to show what happens when something outside your control disrupts your economic model, not to make a claim about Gulf stability in general.

Option (3) — Wrong

This option links the Iran war to the reason Gulf countries are reserving jobs for citizens. That is not right. Those are two separate examples given in support of the same broader claim. The job-reservation trend is ongoing and structural. The Iran war is a sudden event with a specific impact on this year's remittances. The passage presents them as two distinct illustrations, not as cause and effect. The Iran war did not cause Gulf countries to begin reserving jobs. These are independent examples of the same underlying problem — external dependency — and conflating them as cause and effect is a false connection.

Option (4) — Correct

This is the answer. The Iran war is presented in Paragraph 5 as an example of an external shock — something unpredictable, originating outside Kerala, that immediately threatens remittance flows. The option captures this precisely: "the kind of external shock that exposes the fragility of an economic model built on factors that lie outside a state's control." Every element maps directly onto what the paragraph is doing with the Iran war reference. External shock — yes, a war in another region. Exposes the fragility — yes, 20% decline in remittances. Built on factors outside the state's control — yes, that is the paragraph's opening claim, and the Iran war is the example used to illustrate it. This is inference done correctly: one step from the phrase, grounded in its specific function in the argument.

Question 4 Shape 4 — A Numeric Claim

"India's IT exports are now worth more than $220bn annually, more than the $135bn the country earns in total from remittances." Which of the following is a valid conclusion that can be drawn from this statement?

(1) Productive industries built on the skills of those who stayed home can deliver greater economic value than the money sent home by those who left.

(2) The Indian IT industry has become so large that it has reduced the country's reliance on remittance income from its citizens working overseas.

(3) The Indian government has been more successful in promoting service exports than in supporting the welfare of its overseas workforce.

(4) Countries that succeed in retaining their highly skilled workers will outperform those that lose such workers to wealthier nations.

Correct Answer: (1)

Type

Inference-Closed · Shape 4 (A Numeric Claim)

The Demand

The anchor here is a pair of numbers: $220bn for IT exports, $135bn for total remittances. The question asks for a valid conclusion from this statement — and that word "statement" is important. The conclusion must follow from the numbers themselves, not from the entire paragraph. The numbers are in Paragraph 3, and you can use the context of Paragraph 3 to understand what the numbers represent — but the conclusion must be constrained by what the comparison actually tells you.

What does the comparison tell you? IT exports earn more than remittances. That is the stated fact. The context tells you more: the IT industry grew from the skills of people who stayed behind and built a domestic export capability from the aspiration of emigration. Remittances are the income sent back by people who actually left. So the comparison is, implicitly, between the economic value generated by people who stayed and people who left.

Anticipate

The correct option should reflect the comparison: $220bn (IT, built by people who stayed) versus $135bn (remittances from people who left). The inference should be something like: domestic industry built on the skills of those who stayed generated more value than the income sent back by those who went. It should not go further — no claims about government policy, no universal rules about retention, no claim that remittances are no longer needed.

Option (1) — Correct

This is the answer. "Productive industries built on the skills of those who stayed home can deliver greater economic value than the money sent home by those who left." Break it apart: IT exports ($220bn) are productive industries; they grew from the skills of Indians who trained for Silicon Valley but stayed in Bangalore — people who stayed home. Remittances ($135bn) are the money sent home by those who left. $220bn is greater than $135bn. The conclusion is exactly what the numbers support, read through the context Paragraph 3 provides. Every word in this option is earned. The hedge "can deliver" rather than "always delivers" or "will deliver" keeps the inference appropriately bounded.

Option (2) — Wrong

This option says the IT industry "has reduced the country's reliance on remittance income." That is a claim about what has happened to India's relationship with remittances — and nothing in the quoted statement supports it. The statement says IT exports are larger than remittances. It does not say India no longer relies on remittances, or that remittance reliance has decreased, or that the IT industry has replaced anything. The numbers show relative size, not displacement. This is a scope error: the option reads the comparison as a claim about structural change in India's economy when the numbers only establish one figure being larger than another.

Option (3) — Wrong

This is an alien idea. The Indian government does not appear anywhere in the quoted statement, and the passage does not compare government performance across domains. The quoted sentence is about the economic output of the IT sector versus remittances — it says nothing about government policy, promotion of exports, or welfare of overseas workers. This option introduces a framing — government success versus failure — that has no basis in the statement or in Paragraph 3. Eliminate it cleanly.

Option (4) — Wrong

This option makes a sweeping universal claim: countries that retain skilled workers "will outperform" those that lose them. Two problems. First, the quoted statement is about India specifically — it does not make a claim about countries in general. Second, "will outperform" is extreme. The passage does not say India outperforms other countries because of retention. The whole story of brain circulation is that some people went to Silicon Valley, some stayed, and the staying-behind created an industry — it is not a story about retention as policy. And Kenny's research in Paragraph 2 specifically notes that emigration's effects are conditional, not universal. A blanket "will outperform" claim sits far beyond what the numbers say.

OVERALL LEARNING

The lesson has one central argument: Inference-Closed is one type, not four. The technique does not change because the question's costume changes. What changes is the shape of the anchor — a quoted line, two names, a phrase, a number. Once you have identified the anchor and located its home in the passage, the rest of the method is identical to what you have always done with closed questions.

The four shapes each carry a specific trap worth holding on to. When the anchor is a quoted line, the trap is that the quotation feels like permission to infer broadly. It does not. The quoted sentence is a compressed argument — your job is to unpack it precisely, not to use it as a launchpad. The correct option will be a close, careful paraphrase. The wrong options will smuggle in causal claims, motivations, or connections the sentence never establishes.

When the anchor is a shared view, the trap is answering for only one of the two named people. The question explicitly requires both. Before considering any option, ask of each named person separately: does the passage actually say they would agree with this? An option can be perfectly accurate about one scholar and still be wrong if the other scholar never touches the relevant claim.

When the anchor is a phrase reference, the trap is zooming out too quickly. The phrase is doing a specific job in a specific sentence. Nearby sentences contain real passage content that will be used to build wrong options — broad conclusions, adjacent causes, thematic claims. Stay anchored to the phrase and its immediate context. What is this phrase illustrating? What argument is it supporting?

When the anchor is a numeric claim, the trap is reading the numbers as permission to make structural claims. Numbers tell you one thing: relative size, or quantity. They do not tell you about causation, government policy, universal patterns, or what has changed over time. The correct conclusion from a comparison of two figures stays within what those figures establish.

Carry this forward: the Inference-Closed type is generous. It tells you exactly where to look. It is not asking you to reason across the whole passage or hold the author's entire argument in your head. It is asking you to go to a specific place, read what is there, and take one step. The danger is overstepping. The discipline of staying anchored — not leaping, not inferring further than the evidence allows — is what separates a correct answer from a tempting wrong one.

WHERE WE ARE

Module 3 has spent the last several lessons building a full picture of open questions. In Day 4, we dealt with Local Open questions — stems that tell you something is true and then ask you to find the one exception. The defining feature was the word 'true' or something functionally equivalent. The content could be anywhere across the passage, which is what made them open rather than closed, but the underlying demand was always straightforward: retrieve something factual and find the one option that does not fit.

Then in Day 5, we covered inference in the closed format — questions that contain an inference marker in the stem but also give you a specific pointer to tell you exactly where to look. That lesson's central insight was that 'inferred' in CAT almost always means 'true.' The same method — doodle, demand, anticipate, eliminate — applies throughout.

This lesson, Day 6 Lesson 1, brings the two together: inference and open in combination. The stem contains an inference marker — can be inferred, valid inference, implied, suggested, valid conclusion — and at the same time gives you no specific pointer. The information could be anywhere. That is what makes these questions feel harder than they are. The lesson exists to show you that they are not.

WHAT IS AN INFERENCE OPEN QUESTION?

An Inference Open question has two features. First, it contains an inference marker in the stem — words like 'can be inferred,' 'valid inference from the passage,' 'can be concluded,' 'is implied,' 'is suggested.' Second, it contains no specific pointer. There is no 'according to paragraph 3' or 'as mentioned in the discussion of X.' The question leaves you with the entire passage as your search space.

That combination creates the particular difficulty of this question type. In a closed question, even with an inference marker, you know where to go. In an open question, even without an inference marker, you have your doodle to guide you through the passage structure. In an Inference Open question you have both problems simultaneously — you are searching the whole passage and the stem is dressed up in language that makes students feel they need to do something more complex than they actually do.

The method for Inference Open questions is the same method you have always used. Doodle. Decode the demand. Trust the doodle to evaluate each option. Eliminate. Verify only when two options remain.

WHERE IT SITS IN THE PAPER

Across the full CAT question bank, Inference Open questions make up 38% of all inference questions. Measured against all RC questions in CAT, they account for roughly 9%. That is a meaningful share — not trivial, not dominant, but consistent enough to be worth understanding properly.

Year-wise, the frequency varies considerably by IIM. IIM Lucknow's 2017 paper had zero. IIM Calcutta's 2018 paper had 4%. IIM Kozhikode in 2019 had 2%. IIM Indore in 2020 had 7% — and with IIM Indore conducting CAT 2026, that figure is the most directly relevant. IIM Ahmedabad (2021) set 10%, IIM Bangalore (2022) pushed the figure to 21%, and IIM Lucknow returned in 2023 with 17%. IIM Calcutta's 2024 paper brought it back to 6%, and IIM Kozhikode in 2025 sat at 8%.

There is no hard pattern in these numbers. What matters is that in any given year, Inference Open questions can range from absent to accounting for one in five RC questions. The setter's temperament shapes the distribution more than any predictable formula. IIM Indore is a moderate setter, not a zero setter. Prepare accordingly.

TWO FLAVOURS OF THE QUESTION

Inference Open questions come in two varieties. The vast majority — 81% — are Find the Distortion questions. Three options can be inferred from the passage. One cannot. You are asked to find the one that cannot. The challenge is that you have to evaluate all four options across the full passage to locate the floater.

The remaining 19% are Find the Truth questions. Three options cannot be inferred. One can. The cognitive flip is the difficulty — you are no longer looking for the odd one out, you are looking for the single thing that holds. This is subtler because three plausible-sounding options are actually wrong, and you have to trust the one that quietly lines up with the passage.

The stem phrasing tells you which flavour you are dealing with. For Find the Distortion questions, you will see: 'All of the following can be inferred from the passage EXCEPT'; 'Which of the following is not a valid inference?'; 'It can be inferred from the passage that the author is not likely to support.' For Find the Truth questions, you will see: 'Which of the following can be inferred from the passage?'; 'None of the following can be inferred EXCEPT'; 'It can be inferred that the author is in favour of.'

There is a mechanical way to decode the polarity with certainty. Count the negatives in the stem. If the total is odd — one negative — you are finding the distortion. If the total is even — zero or two negatives — you are finding the truth. 'All can be inferred EXCEPT' has one negative (EXCEPT), so: find the distortion. 'None may be rejected as valid inferences EXCEPT' has two negatives (none, rejected), so: find the truth. Count the negatives. The technique does not change.

DISTORTION PROFILE — WHAT WRONG OPTIONS LOOK LIKE

The STEALS tags that appear in Inference Open questions follow a consistent distribution. Sidetrack Twist is the dominant distortion at 47% — a real passage idea or real passage actor, bent slightly. The setter borrows the vocabulary of the passage but adds, removes, or shifts something just enough to make the claim untrue. This is the hardest type to catch precisely because the words feel familiar.

Lie comes second at 24% — a direct contradiction or reversal of what the passage says. Alien Idea is third at 20% — a concept genuinely absent from the passage, often introduced at the same level of sophistication as the passage's actual ideas. Tone Mismatch accounts for 4% — the intensity is bumped, typically from a tentative suggestion in the passage to a confident assertion in the option. Extreme is another 4% — absolute language like 'always,' 'never,' 'all' applied to something the passage treats as partial or contextual. Scope is only 2%.

The practical consequence: when you are doing Inference Open questions, you are primarily hunting Sidetrack Twists and Lies. You are asking yourself about each option — does this idea exist in the passage, and if so, has the setter bent it? Is the actor right? Is the direction of the claim right? Is the causal relationship one the passage actually makes, or has a false connection been inserted?

THE METHOD

Step 1 is the doodle. Before any question, you have read the passage and built your mental map — which paragraph is doing what, what the key idea of each paragraph is, where the argument moves. This is your primary tool for the entire question set. You are not re-reading the passage per question. You are trusting what you have already built.

Step 2 is the demand. Read the question stem. Decode the polarity. Identify whether you are finding the one distortion or the one truth. Note whether the stem gives you any directional hint — even open questions sometimes specify a topic which narrows the relevant paragraphs somewhat.

Step 3 is evaluation, not verification. Take each option to your doodle, not to the passage. Ask: which paragraph does this claim come from? Is the claim broadly consistent with what that paragraph was doing? Is anything in this option adding something the paragraph did not contain? Flag options that do not match cleanly. Do not go back to the passage at this stage.

Step 4 is conclusion. If one option clearly floats — fails the doodle test — that is your answer. If two options remain and you are uncertain, go to the passage for a targeted verification of those two only. One well-built doodle, used consistently, is what handles these questions.

THE PASSAGE

THE PASSAGE

Source: *'We Bought an Orchestra'* · *Jeffrey Arlo Brown* · *The Baffler*

Stats: 519 words | 27 sentences | 19.2 avg. words per sentence | Flesch–Kincaid Grade: 13.1

Reading Difficulty: Grade 13.1 — literate journalism with a strong author voice. This is an opinion piece, not an academic argument. The author has a position and shows it. Read for stance, not just content.

¶1 Classical music has always been dependent on elite patronage. In Europe's monarchies, royals and nobility kept musicians as glorified servants. ... Music patronage took on a more democratic flavor in the twentieth century. ... While the meritocracy so essential to the field's aura was never perfect, in recent decades most anyone making a career in classical music was extremely skilled. Perhaps they were skilled because they had parents who were wealthy or musical or both, but they were skilled, nonetheless.

¶2 The musical adventuring of socialite-turned-soprano Florence Foster Jenkins and financial-publisher-turned-conductor Gilbert Kaplan and conductor-turned-Valium-baron Paul Sacher show that rich people never really lost their desire to prove themselves in the musical realm. But the last decade or so has seen a striking rise in pay-to-play arrangements, a situation that recalls the days when orchestras belonged to princes. These experiences allow people with money but little musical ability to roleplay composer and conductor—for a price. This development flows naturally from this era's extreme inequality as well as classical music's precarious state, even in such historically generous countries as Germany. It risks reshaping the art itself to align with the whims of wealthy dilettantes.

¶3 Examples abound. In 2012, Alexey Kononenko, a former mathematician at the mysterious hedge fund Renaissance Technologies, began a career as a composer. Despite never having learned to play an instrument, a rudimentary grasp of music theory, and a ratio of inspiration to imitation that would embarrass a large language model, Kononenko, who goes by the stage name Alexey Shor, has had his works performed all over the world by many of its best musicians. Shor has bankrolled a dizzying array of concerts, festivals, and competitions. The catch is that they must all include Shor's own works. ... Or consider Susan Lim. Last May, the Royal Philharmonic Orchestra, the City of London Choir, and the outstanding pianist Jean-Yves Thibaudet gave a performance of a composition by the surgeon and AI booster, who hired musicians to turn her inchoate ideas about technology into music and allow herself the privilege of calling herself a "songwriter." ...

¶4 Pay-to-conduct opportunities are becoming more common too. In June, the technology executive Mandle Cheung shelled out $400,000 to conduct the Toronto Symphony Orchestra in Mahler's "Resurrection" Symphony. In November, Richard Grenell, the former president of the Trump Kennedy Center, awkwardly led the National Symphony Orchestra in a rendition of the national anthem. It was an advertisement for the since-closed Center's fundraising initiative that would allow wealthy donors to take the baton in exchange for large donations. "With a large contribution, you can conduct the National Anthem at @kencen—an unforgettable, once-in-a-lifetime experience!" read the social media copy. ...

¶5 All this make-believe art making has an uncanny quality. The concerts look and sound a lot like normal concerts, with professional musicians picking up the wealthy dabbler's slack. The overall effect is hard to localize at first, but it boils down to this: Rich people are building their own classical music world, one where the long years of intense training, fierce competition, and harrowing precarity musicians endure to master their craft matter less than access to cold, hard cash.

READING THE PASSAGE — PARAGRAPH BY PARAGRAPH

Build the map before you see the questions. Five paragraphs, five doodles. The doodle is what you carry into all four questions.

Paragraph 1 — Classical music and elite patronage

Paragraph 1 sets the historical baseline. Classical music has always depended on wealthy support — from monarchies and nobles who kept musicians essentially as servants, through the twentieth century when patronage became more broadly democratic. The author's key concession is that even if skill was sometimes a product of privilege (wealthy or musical parents), in recent decades the people who made careers in this field were extremely skilled. The word 'always' is in the passage, which means it is fair in an option — it is not an extreme distortion when the passage itself uses it. The doodle captures the baseline and the important qualifier.

Doodle: *Classical music → always needed elite patronage. 20th century → more democratic. But skill remained essential.*

Paragraph 2 — Pay-to-play rises; inequality and precarity are the twin causes

Paragraph 2 is where the argument turns. The author acknowledges that wealthy people's desire to participate in music is not new — Jenkins, Kaplan, and Sacher are examples from earlier decades. But the word 'But' signals the shift: in the last decade, pay-to-play arrangements have risen sharply. The author names two causes: extreme inequality and classical music's financial precarity. These are co-existing enabling conditions, not one causing the other. The danger he identifies is that this risks reshaping the art to suit wealthy dilettantes. Note that word 'risks' — it is a possibility, not a certainty. Any option that removes that tentativeness is a distortion.

Doodle: *Pay-to-play rising (last decade). Causes: extreme inequality + precarity together. Risk: reshaping the art for dilettantes.*

Paragraph 3 — Wealthy dabblers buy composer credentials despite lacking ability

Paragraph 3 gives the examples for pay-to-compose. Alexey Shor has never played an instrument, has a rudimentary grasp of theory, and the author's sharpest insult is that his inspiration-to-imitation ratio would embarrass a large language model. Despite this, he has bankrolled concerts and festivals — with the condition that they include his own works. Susan Lim hired professional musicians to turn her inchoate ideas about technology into music and then claimed the title of 'songwriter.' The scare quotes on 'songwriter' tell you everything about the author's attitude. The doodle: wealthy people paying to be called something they have not earned. The paragraph gives you two clear cases; both are characterised similarly.

Doodle: *Shor (hedge fund): no skill → bankrolls concerts, forces own works in. Susan Lim: hires musicians → calls herself "songwriter." Money buys the title.*

Paragraph 4 — Conducting is also being sold; major institutions are complicit

Paragraph 4 shifts from composition to conducting and extends the pattern. Mandle Cheung paid $400,000 to conduct the Toronto Symphony. Richard Grenell awkwardly led the National Symphony Orchestra as part of a Kennedy Center fundraising initiative explicitly selling the experience to wealthy donors. The social media copy the author quotes — 'an unforgettable, once-in-a-lifetime experience!' — is its own kind of exhibit. The author's contempt is compressed into the word 'awkwardly.' Major, established orchestras are accepting this. That is the point of naming them specifically.

Doodle: *Pay-to-conduct: Cheung ($400K) → Toronto Symphony. Grenell → NSO. Kennedy Center selling baton for donations. Institutions openly complicit.*

Paragraph 5 — Skill displaced by money; professional musicians mask the deception

Paragraph 5 is the conclusion and the author's verdict. These concerts look and sound like real concerts because the professional musicians around the wealthy dabbler are genuinely excellent — they pick up the slack. The uncanny quality is that the performance is real but the credit is false. The final sentence is the thesis: rich people are building their own classical music world in which training, competition, and years of sacrifice matter less than access to money. This is the most important paragraph for option evaluation — the author's central claim is stated here with maximum clarity.

Doodle: *Concerts look/sound normal → professional musicians cover. But: Rich people's world → cash > craft. Training, competition, precarity — matter less.*

QUESTION 1

ONE NEGATIVE · FIND THE DISTORTION

All of the following can be inferred from the passage EXCEPT:

(1) Concerts featuring wealthy dabblers as composers or conductors often sound technically competent to those listening.

(2) Classical music's financial precarity is largely the result of growing economic inequality across modern societies.

(3) Without the financial support of wealthy patrons, classical music may not have survived in the form we know today.

(4) The desire among wealthy individuals to participate in music-making is not a phenomenon unique to the present moment.

Correct Answer: (2)

Type

Inference Open · Find the Distortion (one negative: EXCEPT).

The Demand

One negative: EXCEPT. Net polarity is negative. You are finding the one distortion — the one claim that cannot be inferred from the passage. The other three will be inferable. Your doodle is the tool. There is no specific pointer; options draw from across all five paragraphs.

Anticipate

Before going to the options, think about what is clearly inferable and what is not. Paragraph 5 says the concerts look and sound like normal concerts — so sound quality is inferable. Paragraph 2 says pay-to-play flows from extreme inequality and classical music's precarity — but these are co-existing causes, not one causing the other. Paragraph 1 says classical music has always depended on elite patronage. Paragraph 2 says wealthy people never really lost their desire. Something about a causal relationship in Option 2 will need to be examined carefully.

Option (1) — Keep

Paragraph 5 says the concerts 'look and sound a lot like normal concerts, with professional musicians picking up the wealthy dabbler's slack.' If they look and sound like normal concerts, they sound technically competent. This is a straightforward implied truth — one step from the stated evidence. Option 1 can be inferred.

Tag: Correct as inference — Paragraph 5. Implied truth. Keep.

Option (2) — ANSWER

Paragraph 2 says pay-to-play 'flows naturally from this era's extreme inequality as well as classical music's precarious state.' Read that carefully. The passage lists both extreme inequality and classical music's precarity as the twin causes of pay-to-play arrangements. Option 2 inverts the logic: it says precarity is largely the result of inequality. The passage never claims that. It treats precarity and inequality as co-existing conditions that together enable pay-to-play — not as cause and effect. The option takes two real elements from the same sentence and creates a causal relationship between them that the passage does not authorise.

Tag: S — Sidetrack (Twist). ANSWER. Two real passage elements, false connection between them inserted.

Option (3) — Keep

Paragraph 1 opens with 'Classical music has always been dependent on elite patronage.' If it has always depended on elite support, then without that support its survival in its current form is genuinely in question. The 'may not have' phrasing is appropriately tentative. The inference is valid.

Tag: Correct as inference — Paragraph 1. Implied truth. Keep.

Option (4) — Keep

Paragraph 2 says Jenkins, Kaplan, and Sacher 'show that rich people never really lost their desire to prove themselves in the musical realm.' If the desire was never lost, it is not new to the present moment. Option 4 is a clean paraphrase of this. The inference is valid.

Tag: Correct as inference — Paragraph 2. Paraphrased truth. Keep.

QUESTION 2

TWO NEGATIVES · FIND THE TRUTH

All of the following statements may be rejected as valid inferences from the passage EXCEPT:

(1) Classical music institutions today have come to value financial contributions over the artistic skill of the performers they engage.

(2) Pay-to-play arrangements undermine the principle of merit-based recognition that has long defined the field of classical music.

(3) The participation of wealthy individuals in classical music has been a phenomenon documented across centuries of European cultural history.

(4) The growing influence of donors over institutional artistic choices creates conditions under which the standards of classical music itself can shift.

Correct Answer: (4)

Type

Inference Open · Find the Truth (two negatives: 'rejected' + EXCEPT).

The Demand

Count the negatives. 'Rejected' is one negative. 'EXCEPT' is a second negative. Two negatives = even = find the truth. Three options will be correctly rejected as invalid inferences. One will survive. You are looking for the single option that genuinely can be inferred. This is the harder flavour of the question.

Anticipate

Think about what this passage is actually saying versus what sounds plausible. The passage says classical music is at risk of being shaped by wealthy dilettantes. It identifies precarity and inequality as enabling conditions. It says the art may be reshaped. The correct answer will be something the passage actually supports — not something that sounds like a strong claim but goes beyond what the passage says. Watch for scope issues and Lies dressed up as paraphrases.

Option (1) — Reject

This option is about classical music institutions — plural, general, as a category — having come to value money over performer skill. The passage is about a specific and growing trend, not a generalised institutional value shift. The professional musicians at these events are explicitly said to be excellent. Institutions are tolerating pay-to-play for the money, not claiming that skill no longer matters to them. The option over-generalises and invents an institutional attitude the passage does not describe.

> **Tag: S — Sidetrack (Twist). Correctly rejected.** Over-generalises to all institutions; passage only describes a trend.

Option (2) — Reject

This one is dangerous because it sounds exactly like what the author is arguing. But Paragraph 1 explicitly says 'the meritocracy so essential to the field's aura was never perfect.' The author does not say meritocracy has long defined the field — he says the field had an aura of meritocracy that was never actually perfect. Option 2 presents the field as having had genuine merit-based recognition, which the passage qualifies and undermines. The option takes the author's language and removes the qualification.

> **Tag: S — Sidetrack (Twist). Correctly rejected.** The passage qualifies the meritocracy claim; the option removes the qualification.

Option (3) — Reject

Paragraph 1 mentions monarchies and European nobility. Paragraph 2 mentions Jenkins, Kaplan, and Sacher as individual historical examples. But 'documented across centuries of European cultural history' is a scope claim the passage does not make. The passage gestures at a long history; it does not present a systematic cross-century documentation. The scope of the claim is broader than what the passage actually establishes.

> **Tag: Sc — Scope Issue. Correctly rejected.** Broader scope than the passage claims.

Option (4) — ANSWER

This is directly supported by Paragraph 2: 'It risks reshaping the art itself to align with the whims of wealthy dilettantes,' and by Paragraph 5's conclusion that rich people are building their own classical music world where money matters more than craft. Option 4 does not overclaim — 'creates conditions under which standards can shift' is precisely what the passage says. The risk is named in the passage; the option articulates it accurately. Every word is earned.

Tag: Correct Answer — Implied Truth. Paragraphs 2 and 5 both support this. Appropriately tentative phrasing.

QUESTION 3

NO NEGATIVES · FIND THE TRUTH

Given the historical role of patronage and the rise of pay-to-play arrangements, which of the following conclusions can be drawn about the way classical music is being shaped today?

(1) Despite the rise of pay-to-play arrangements, classical music has retained its meritocratic foundations because professional musicians continue to perform skilfully.

(2) Wealthy interests have come to dominate classical music to such an extent that skilled musicians retain little real say over the direction of the field.

(3) Money has shifted from funding trained artists to letting wealthy individuals take on the artistic roles themselves.

(4) Pay-to-play arrangements are simply a continuation of the patronage tradition, with wealthy individuals playing the same role they always have.

Correct Answer: (3)

Type

Inference Open · Find the Truth (no negatives).

The Demand

No negatives in the stem. Net polarity is positive. Find the truth. The stem gives you a directional hint — 'given the historical role of patronage and the rise of pay-to-play arrangements' — which spans Paragraphs 1 and 2 but really points at the passage's overall argument. You want an option that captures what the passage says is happening to classical music today.

Anticipate

What is the passage actually saying about how classical music is being shaped? The historical patronage gave money to trained musicians. The new arrangement gives money in exchange for letting wealthy amateurs take artistic roles. The passage marks this as a change, not a continuation. Something about the shift in what money buys should be in the correct answer. The author's tone is clearly negative about this development.

Option (1) — Reject

The passage's entire argument is that classical music has not retained its meritocratic foundations — that those foundations are being eroded. Paragraph 5 says cash now matters more than craft. The professional musicians performing well is the disguise that makes the erosion look acceptable; it is not evidence that the foundations are intact. This option uses a real passage element (professional musicians are skilled) to support a conclusion the author actively rejects.

Tag: L — Lie. Uses a true element to support a conclusion that contradicts the passage's argument.

Option (2) — Reject

The passage says nothing about what skilled musicians think, say, or decide. It describes the conditions around them — the concerts they play in, the wealthy people whose slack they pick up — but never comments on whether musicians have or lack influence over the direction of the field. This is a real-world claim that could plausibly be true, but it has no support in the passage. Do not confuse plausibility with inferability.

Tag: A — Alien Idea. No passage support for musician influence over field direction.

Option (3) — ANSWER

This option captures the passage's argument precisely. Paragraph 1 establishes that historical patronage meant wealthy people funding trained musicians. Paragraphs 2, 3, and 4 show that the new arrangement involves wealthy people buying artistic roles for themselves — as composers, conductors, songwriters. The shift is from funding others to occupying the artistic position personally. Option 3 is drawn from combining the historical baseline in Paragraph 1 with the current trend in Paragraphs 2–4. It is an implied combined truth and it earns every word.

Tag: Correct Answer — Implied Combined Truth. Combines Para 1 (history) with Paras 2–4 (current trend).

Option (4) — Reject

The author's entire point is that something has changed. Paragraph 2 signals this with 'But the last decade or so has seen a striking rise in pay-to-play arrangements, a situation that recalls the days when orchestras belonged to princes.' 'Recalls' means resembles, not repeats. The author draws the comparison precisely to show that something has returned which should not have. Option 4 removes the tension the author has spent the entire passage establishing. 'Simply a continuation' and 'the same role they always have' directly contradict the passage.

Tag: L — Lie. 'Simply a continuation' contradicts the passage's central argument about change.

QUESTION 4

ONE NEGATIVE · FIND THE DISTORTION

It can be inferred from the passage that the author is not likely to support the view that:

(1) The Kennedy Center selling conducting opportunities shows that financial precarity has made institutions more receptive to arrangements once considered inappropriate.

(2) Jenkins's example shows that someone with little musical skill could use her wealth to become a recognised soprano in the world of classical music.

(3) The Toronto Symphony performing under Cheung shows that established orchestras can be willing to put a wealthy amateur on the podium in exchange for a large payment.

(4) Shor's concerts featuring his own works show that wealthy dilettantes are reshaping classical music in ways that threaten the field's traditional skill requirements.

Correct Answer: (2)

Type

Inference Open · Find the Distortion (one negative: 'not likely to support').

The Demand

One negative: 'not likely to support.' Net polarity is negative. Find the distortion — the one claim the author would not support. Three options will reflect views the passage actually backs. One will contain something the passage does not authorise, which means the author has no grounds to support it. This question type requires you to evaluate each option against author intent, which is anchored in the passage's evidence.

Anticipate

The author is clearly opposed to pay-to-play. He would support any option that accurately describes a specific example of it and connects that example to what he has said. The distortion will be a view that attributes something to a specific example that the passage does not actually tell us. Jenkins is the one to watch here — she appears in Paragraph 2, and the passage is deliberately imprecise about what she actually did and achieved.

Option (1) — Author would support

Paragraph 2 explicitly says this development 'flows naturally from this era's extreme inequality as well as classical music's precarious state.' Paragraph 4 describes the Kennedy Center's fundraising initiative as an example of pay-to-conduct. Financial precarity drove the Kennedy Center to sell conducting access. The phrase 'once considered inappropriate' is also supported — the author treats this as a new and troubling development. Option 1 is something the author would support.

Tag: Valid inference from Paragraphs 2 and 4. Author supports this. Keep.

Option (2) — ANSWER

This option contains two problems, and either one is enough to eliminate it. First: the passage never says Jenkins had little musical skill. The passage describes her 'musical adventuring' — an ambiguous phrase — and says rich people never lost their desire to prove themselves musically. It does not state that Jenkins was unskilled. Second: the passage never says Jenkins became a 'recognised soprano in the world of classical music.' The label 'socialite-turned-soprano' tells us what she did, not what the classical music world officially recognised her as. The author cannot support a view drawn from evidence the passage does not contain.

Tag: S — Sidetrack (Twist). ANSWER. Two invented claims dressed up as inferences from the Jenkins example.

Option (3) — Author would support

Paragraph 4 says Cheung shelled out $400,000 to conduct the Toronto Symphony. The Toronto Symphony is an established orchestra. Cheung, a technology executive, is the kind of wealthy amateur the passage is describing throughout. Option 3 accurately characterises what happened. The author would have no objection to this view.

Tag: Valid inference from Paragraph 4. Author supports this. Keep.

Option (4) — Author would support

Paragraph 3 describes Shor in detail — no instrument, rudimentary theory, yet concerts and festivals with his own works mandated. Paragraph 5 says rich people are building a world where training and competition matter less than cash. Option 4 connects Shor's example to the passage's central conclusion. The author's entire argument is that this is happening and it is bad. He would support Option 4.

Tag: Valid inference from Paragraphs 3 and 5. Author supports this. Keep.

OVERALL LEARNING

Four questions from one passage. Four different polarities. The same method throughout. What this lesson has shown you is that the polarity of the stem changes what you are hunting — the one distortion or the one truth — but it does not change how you hunt it. You doodle. You decode the demand. You take options to the doodle. You eliminate.

The polarity trick is the mechanical tool that should now be automatic. Count the negatives in the stem. If odd, find the distortion. If even, find the truth. Apply it every time you see an Inference Open question, regardless of how the stem is phrased. The counting takes seconds and removes ambiguity.

The distortion profile matters. In this question type, Sidetrack Twists account for nearly half of all wrong options — 47%. The setter takes a real passage element, a real person, a real argument, and bends it slightly. Option 2 in Question 1 took a real causal sentence and inverted the relationship between its two elements. Option 2 in Question 4 took a real figure from the passage and attributed to her things the passage never said. The language was recognisable; the claim was invented. Recognising Sidetrack Twists requires you to check not just whether the words appear in the passage but whether the relationship between those words appears in the passage.

Truth type matters too. 60% of correct answers and valid truths in this question type are implied or combined — drawn from connecting two parts of the passage or taking one logical step beyond what is stated. Question 3's correct answer required you to combine Paragraph 1's account of historical patronage with Paragraphs 2–4's account of the current arrangement to arrive at a conclusion neither paragraph states alone. That is how implied combined truth works. It is not reading between the lines — it is reading across the lines you have already understood.

One final thing this lesson should reinforce: the difficulty of a question in this category is not in the label of the question type. It is entirely in how the options are constructed. Your doodle is what allows you to stay grounded when the options are trying to move you away from the passage. The doodle does not need to be perfect — it needs to be honest. Whatever you have genuinely understood, use it. The passage always has the answer.

LESSON HANDOUT

Module: Know the Question Stems – RC

Lesson 3.6.1: Inference – Open Questions – 2

WHERE WE ARE

Part 1 of this lesson series established everything that matters about Open Inference questions. We established that when a question carries an inference marker but gives no paragraph anchor, the entire passage is in scope. We established that so-called inference in CAT is almost never deductive logic — it is passage truth, either paraphrased or implied by combining ideas across paragraphs. We looked at the STEALS breakdown for this question type: **Sidetrack-Twist** accounts for roughly **47%** of distortions, **Lie** for **24%**, and **Alien** for **20%**. Between them, those three account for more than 90% of the traps. We also established a four-step working method: doodle the passage, read the demand, take each option to the doodle, and verify from the passage when you are not sure.

Part 2 picks up exactly where that left off. The logic does not change. What changes is the costume.

CAT question setters have far more creative control over how they frame inference questions than students typically expect. A **synthesis question** asks you to combine what two named people said in two named paragraphs and draw a conclusion. An **odd-pair-out question** gives you four comparative pairs and asks you to find the one whose relationship is different in kind from the others. A **pair-selection question** asks you to identify which two sentences from the passage together best capture a particular idea. A **scoped EXCEPT question** limits the inference to a particular theme or topic and asks you which of the four options cannot be drawn from the passage on that theme.

None of these framings require a different method. They just require you to read the demand carefully enough to know what game is being played. The doodle does the heavy lifting. The demand tells you what lens to apply. The rest is standard option-evaluation.

THE FOUR FRAMINGS: WHAT TO KNOW BEFORE YOU SEE THE QUESTIONS

Framing 1 — Multi-Source Synthesis

The question names two or more specific sources — a named researcher, a named paragraph, a named statement — and asks you what conclusion can be drawn from combining them. Your job is to hold both sources in your head at once, understand what each is saying individually, and find the option that faithfully combines them without overstating either. The most common trap is the **Sidetrack-Twist**: the setter picks up what one source says, combines it with something from the other source, and introduces a word or claim that pushes the conclusion further than both sources together would justify. Watch for intensifiers: 'will', 'always', 'definitively', 'proves', 'ensures'. These push tentative claims into certainties. The passage may say 'might' or 'could' — the trap says 'will' or 'likely will'.

Framing 2 — Odd-Pair-Out

You are given four pairs of concepts or terms. Three pairs share the same kind of relationship as each other. One pair has a different relationship. Your job is to identify the one whose relationship is of a different *kind*. The key word in the demand is '*nature of the relationship*'. You are not being asked which fact is most important. You are being asked which pair has a relationship that is categorically different from the relationship the other three pairs have. Go to your doodle. Identify what the passage says about each pair. Mark each as: same / different / not directly compared. The odd one out will be clear.

Framing 3 — Pair Selection

You are given four pairs of actual sentences from the passage. You must identify which pair of sentences best captures a specific idea named in the question. Before going to the options, be clear about what you are trying to capture. The question will name a specific idea. Go back to where that idea lives in the passage. Understand what the *two conditions* of that idea are. Then look for a pair of sentences that gives you both sides — not one side, both sides. The trap is choosing a pair that gives you only one side of a two-sided idea.

Framing 4 — Scoped EXCEPT

This is an EXCEPT question with a scope marker in the demand. The question tells you: based only on what the passage says about topic X, which of the following cannot be inferred? You are working with what the passage says specifically on the named topic. The correct answer is the one that either goes beyond what the passage says, contradicts it, or introduces a false causal or logical connection. Three options will be straightforward passage truths on the named topic. One will break somewhere. The most reliable break: a **false causal claim** — two events described in sequence, presented in the option as if one caused the other.

THE PASSAGE

Source: *Do octopus brains work like humans' — or is there another way to be smart?*, Liam Drew, *Nature*

Stats: 508 words | 34 sentences | 14.9 avg. words per sentence | Flesch–Kincaid Grade: 11.5

Reading Difficulty: Grade 11.5 — popular science. Easy reading. The challenge is structural — multiple researchers, multiple claims, two parallel comparison threads. Doodle carefully.

¶1 Three hearts; blue blood; no skeleton; arms like tongues. These are just some of the alien features of octopuses, squid and cuttlefish — members of the cephalopod family. The outlandish list continues. Cephalopod skin can taste chemicals, sense light and change colour and texture rapidly. In many species, the sucker-covered arms can even regenerate. . . .

¶2 [The cephalopods] have evolved independently from the vertebrate lineage for more than 600 million years. . . . Despite this evolutionary gulf, vertebrates and these highly specialized molluscs share strange similarities. Their eyes, for example. 'It's eerie how similar they ended up,' says Cristopher Niell, a neuroscientist at the University of Oregon in Eugene. 'The convergent evolution of the eye still blows my mind.'

¶3 Now, [another] similarity is spurring a boom in cephalopod neuroscience. Around 400 million years ago, cuttlefish, squid and octopuses diverged from the only other living cephalopods — the nautiluses. They then lost their protective shells and evolved brains that are uniquely large among invertebrates. These brains bestow the soft-bodied cephalopods with high intelligence. Cuttlefish, squid and octopuses have excellent memories, use tools and are adept problem-solvers; they have a concept of time and are capable of delayed gratification.

¶4 Cephalopods are the only non-vertebrate animals that have big, smart brains. . . . Neuroscientists have gained a wealth of knowledge about how vertebrate brains work, but are increasingly looking to cephalopods for insights into ways to build large, high-functioning nervous systems. 'It is incredibly exciting for those of us who are interested in figuring out the rules of how brains work,' says Carrie Albertin, a cephalopod researcher. . . . 'This is very clearly an elaborate brain driving elaborate behaviours.' . . . .

¶5 A rudimentary look at the cephalopod nervous system reveals that there is more than one way to construct a large, smart brain. . . . Cephalopod brains are doughnut-shaped organs built around the oesophagus. . . . A large number of a cephalopod's neurons — more than half in the case of octopuses — are located in the eight nerve cords, or minibrains, that control the arms. . . . Although octopus eyes resemble those of vertebrates, the visual system in the brain does not. 'It's hard to convey how different it is,' says Niell. 'We just have no idea of how it functions.' . . .

¶6 The overarching questions are whether these differences are just superficial and whether therefore cephalopod brains operate through the same principles as do vertebrate ones. It might be the case that once they are mapped, circuits of neurons turn out to be organized in comparable ways in cephalopods and mammals, says Gilles Laurent, a systems neuroscientist. . . . 'But it could be that you have to be even more abstract than that and figure out what computation is being accomplished' before you find the parallels, he says. . . .

¶7 Whether or not cephalopod brains work like vertebrates, studying them should be a win–win situation. 'Either it's going to tell us that there are these fundamental principles shared by all brains,' says Tessa Montague, a cuttlefish neurobiologist, . . 'or, if they actually do things differently, then that's pretty amazing, too, because that tells you that there are different ways to build a complex, functional brain.'

READING THE PASSAGE — PARAGRAPH BY PARAGRAPH

The passage is a popular science article from *Nature*. The author is not arguing a thesis — the article is reporting and synthesising research. This means names of researchers are used to attribute findings, not to evaluate competing positions. When Niell says something, it is a finding. When Laurent says something, it is a hypothesis. Do not over-read the quotes as debate. The challenge is structural: seven paragraphs, four named researchers, two interlocking threads of comparison between cephalopods and vertebrates. If you read this as a stream of sentences without building a map, the questions will feel disorienting. If your doodle is solid, even the more unusual framings will feel manageable.

¶1 — The Opening: Cephalopods Are Alien

The passage opens with a list of outlandish features: three hearts, blue blood, no skeleton, arms like tongues. The paragraph is doing one simple job: establishing that cephalopods are strikingly unlike anything we normally think of as intelligent life. There is no argument here yet. There is only scene-setting.

Doodle: *Cephalopods are biologically alien — outlandish features.*

¶2 — Despite Separate Lineages, Cephalopods Converge with Vertebrates

Now the pivot. Cephalopods and vertebrates have been evolving independently for over 600 million years — an enormous evolutionary gulf. And yet they share strange similarities. The example given is the eye. Niell calls this eerie. The idea of **convergent evolution** — that very different lineages can independently arrive at similar biological solutions — is introduced here.

Doodle: *Cephalopods and vertebrates: evolved separately (600m years) — but share similar eyes.*

¶3 — Cephalopods Evolved Uniquely Large Brains and High Intelligence

The word 'Now' signals a move to another similarity: brain size. 400 million years ago, the cuttlefish-squid-octopus branch split from nautiluses. In doing so, they lost their shells and evolved unusually large brains for invertebrates. Those large brains gave them high intelligence: memory, tool use, problem-solving, concept of time, delayed gratification. This is the core factual foundation of the passage — keep it close.

Doodle: *Cephalopods: lost shells → large brains → high intelligence.*

¶4 — A Unique Scientific Opportunity

The author now makes the scientific significance explicit. We know a great deal about vertebrate brains. Cephalopods are the **only non-vertebrate animals** with comparably large, smart brains. That makes them uniquely valuable for understanding whether there is more than one way to build a high-functioning brain. Albertin's excitement is the passage's excitement.

Doodle: *Cephalopods = only non-vertebrate big-brained animals — a unique scientific opportunity.*

¶5 — Cephalopod Brains Are Structurally Very Different

Now the structural details. The cephalopod brain is doughnut-shaped, built around the oesophagus. More than half of an octopus's neurons are in the eight arm-nerve cords rather than in the central brain. Most importantly: octopus eyes look like vertebrate eyes, but the visual brain system does not. Niell says we have no idea how it functions. This is the key tension in the passage. **Eyes: similar. Brain architecture: very different.**

Doodle: *Cephalopod brains are structurally alien. Eyes look similar, but visual brain system does not.*

¶6 — The Open Question: Parallels Possibly at Computational Level

The overarching question is now stated directly: are the structural differences superficial, or do cephalopods operate through entirely different principles? Laurent raises two possibilities. One: maybe once circuits are mapped, comparable patterns will emerge. Two: maybe you need to go to a more abstract level — **computation** — to find the parallels. The key word is '**might**'. Nothing is certain. The question is still open.

Doodle: *Open question — parallels might exist, possibly at the computational level.*

¶7 — Either Way, Studying Cephalopods Is a Win–Win

The concluding position. Whether cephalopod brains turn out to share fundamental principles with vertebrate brains, or whether they turn out to be genuinely different, the science wins either way. Similarity would confirm universal principles. Difference would reveal that there are multiple ways to build a complex functional brain.

Doodle: *Either outcome — shared principles or different architectures — is scientifically valuable.*

THE QUESTIONS

Question 1 • *Framing 1 — Multi-Source Synthesis*

Given Niell's observation in the fifth paragraph and Laurent's statement in the sixth paragraph, which of the following conclusions can be most reasonably drawn?

(1) The structural differences in cephalopod brains suggest that scientific parallels with vertebrate brains may not yield much insight.

(2) The convergent evolution of cephalopod eyes points to a similarly convergent evolution of the visual systems within their brains.

(3) Parallels between cephalopod and vertebrate brains may exist at the level of computation even where their physical structures differ.

(4) Studies of cephalopod brains will likely make computational analysis the standard method for comparing brains across species.

Correct Answer: (3)

The Demand

This is a multi-source synthesis question. The demand explicitly names two sources: Niell's observation in paragraph five, and Laurent's statement in paragraph six. We must combine these two specific inputs and find the option that correctly draws from both. Before going to the options, pin down what each source actually says. Niell says the visual system in the cephalopod brain is profoundly different from vertebrates' and that we have no idea how it functions. Laurent says it might be the case that comparable patterns emerge once circuits are mapped, but that we might need to go even more abstract — to the level of computation — before finding the parallels. Both sources carry important epistemic hedging: 'hard to convey', 'might be', 'could be'. The answer must honour that tentativeness.

Anticipate

Combining Niell and Laurent: the physical structures are very different (maybe incomprehensibly so), but parallels might still exist — possibly at a more abstract computational level. The answer should preserve the 'maybe'. It should not overstate certainty, and it should not collapse Niell's point (difference) into the wrong direction.

Kill the Options

Option (1): The structural differences in cephalopod brains suggest that scientific parallels with vertebrate brains may not yield much insight.

Tag: L — Lie. This directly contradicts the passage. The entire arc — from Albertin's excitement in paragraph four to Montague's win-win framing in paragraph seven — is premised on the idea that cephalopod brains are enormously scientifically valuable precisely because they are different. Niell himself is not saying 'this is hopeless'. He is saying 'we do not yet know how it works'. Laurent follows immediately with reasons why parallels might yet be found. This option takes the fact of structural difference and uses it to imply scientific futility. That is the opposite of what the passage says.

Option (2): The convergent evolution of cephalopod eyes points to a similarly convergent evolution of the visual systems within their brains.

Tag: L — Lie. Paragraph five states explicitly that although octopus eyes resemble those of vertebrates, the visual system in the brain does not. The convergent evolution of the eye is a real passage idea. But the option uses it to imply that the visual brain system is also convergent. That is precisely what Niell is denying. If anything, this option is the opposite of what the synthesis of Niell's observation yields.

Option (3): Parallels between cephalopod and vertebrate brains may exist at the level of computation even where their physical structures differ.

Tag: Correct Answer. This is a precise and appropriately hedged combination of both sources. The first clause — parallels may exist at the computational level — directly captures Laurent's suggestion in paragraph six. The second clause — even where physical structures differ — captures Niell's observation in paragraph five. The word 'may' respects the tentativeness of Laurent's language. Neither source is overstated. Every word is earned.

Option (4): Studies of cephalopod brains will likely make computational analysis the standard method for comparing brains across species.

Tag: S — Scope Issue / Sidetrack-Twist. Laurent mentions computation as a possible route to finding parallels between cephalopods and vertebrates. But nobody in the passage says this will become the standard method for comparing brains across species generally. Additionally, 'will likely' replaces the passage's 'might' and 'could be' with a level of certainty the passage never authorises. Two problems: too broad in scope, too certain in tone.

Question 2 • *Framing 2 — Odd-Pair-Out*

On the basis of the nature of the relationship between the items in each pair below, choose the odd pair out:

(1) Cephalopod visual processing : Vertebrate visual processing
(2) Cephalopod neuron distribution : Vertebrate neuron distribution
(3) Cephalopod brain shape : Vertebrate brain shape
(4) Cephalopod eye structure : Vertebrate eye structure

Correct Answer: (4)

The Demand

This question is not asking which pair is most important, or which pair appears earliest in the passage. It is asking about the nature of the relationship within each pair. The key word is 'nature'. The relationship between two items can be one of similarity or one of difference. You need to determine, for each pair, whether the passage describes those two items as similar or as different. Three pairs will share the same kind of relationship. One will be the odd one out because its relationship is of a different kind.

Anticipate

Go through each pair systematically. Cephalopod visual processing vs. vertebrate: paragraph five says the visual system in the brain does not resemble that of vertebrates — different. Neuron distribution: more than half of octopus neurons are in arm nerve cords; vertebrates concentrate neurons in the central brain — different. Brain shape: doughnut-shaped around the oesophagus vs. standard vertebrate architecture — different. Eye structure: paragraphs two and five both confirm the eye is strikingly similar across both lineages — similar. Three pairs are different. One pair is similar. Option (4) is the odd one out.

Kill the Options

Option (1): Cephalopod visual processing : Vertebrate visual processing

Tag: True (Different) — Eliminate. Paragraph five is explicit. The visual system in the cephalopod brain does not resemble that of vertebrates. Niell says it is hard to convey how different it is. Relationship: different. Same kind as options (2) and (3). Eliminate.

Option (2): Cephalopod neuron distribution : Vertebrate neuron distribution

Tag: True (Different) — Eliminate. More than half of an octopus's neurons are located in the arm nerve cords, not the central brain. Vertebrate neuron distribution is structured very differently. Relationship: different. Eliminate.

Option (3): Cephalopod brain shape : Vertebrate brain shape

Tag: True (Different) — Eliminate. Cephalopod brains are doughnut-shaped organs built around the oesophagus. That is not how vertebrate brains are described. Relationship: different. Note: the question asks about shape, not size. Brain size is a shared feature; brain shape is not. Do not confuse the two.

Option (4): Cephalopod eye structure : Vertebrate eye structure

Tag: Correct Answer — Odd Pair Out. Paragraphs two and five both address the eye. Niell in paragraph two says the convergent evolution of the eye 'blows his mind' because of how similar they ended up. Paragraph five confirms: octopus eyes resemble those of vertebrates. Relationship: similar. This is the only pair in the group where the relationship is similarity rather than difference. It is the odd one out.

Question 3 • *Framing 3 — Pair Selection*

Which pair of sentences from the passage best captures the 'win–win situation' mentioned in the last paragraph?

(1) 'Cephalopod brains are doughnut-shaped organs built around the oesophagus.' AND 'A large number of a cephalopod's neurons — more than half in the case of octopuses — are located in the eight nerve cords, or minibrains, that control the arms.'

(2) 'The convergent evolution of the eye still blows my mind.' AND 'Cuttlefish, squid and octopuses have excellent memories, use tools and are adept problem-solvers.'

(3) 'Cephalopod skin can taste chemicals, sense light and change colour and texture rapidly.' AND 'Cephalopods are the only non-vertebrate animals that have big, smart brains.'

(4) 'The convergent evolution of the eye still blows my mind.' AND 'Although octopus eyes resemble those of vertebrates, the visual system in the brain does not.'

Correct Answer: (4)

The Demand

Before touching the options, be precise about what 'win–win situation' means in paragraph seven. Montague says: either cephalopod brains share fundamental principles with all brains (which is valuable), or they do things differently (which is also valuable, because it tells us there are multiple ways to build a complex functional brain). The win-win is built on two conditions: similarity and difference. Both are scientifically exciting. Both count as a win. So we need a pair of sentences that together give us one statement of similarity and one statement of difference, in the context of the cephalopod-vertebrate comparison.

Anticipate

The answer must give both sides: a sentence capturing something that is similar between cephalopods and vertebrates, and a sentence capturing something that is different. Three of the four options fail this test because they give you only one side. Find the pair that has both.

Kill the Options

Option (1): 'Cephalopod brains are doughnut-shaped.' AND 'Neurons in arm nerve cords.'

Tag: S — Sidetrack. Both sentences describe structural differences between cephalopod and vertebrate brains. There is no similarity here. Win-win requires both a similarity-win and a difference-win. This pair gives you only the difference side. Eliminate.

Option (2): 'Convergent evolution of the eye.' AND 'Excellent memories, use tools.'

Tag: S — Sidetrack. Both sentences here describe things that are shared or impressive about cephalopods in comparison to vertebrates — similar eyes, comparable intelligence markers. Both point toward similarity. There is no difference captured. This is only one side of the win-win. Eliminate.

Option (3): 'Skin can taste chemicals.' AND 'Only non-vertebrate with large brains.'

Tag: S — Sidetrack with Alien element. The first sentence about skin tasting chemicals is from paragraph one, describing cephalopod alien biology. It is never placed in explicit comparison with vertebrate skin. It is not a comparative similarity or difference in the way the win-win argument requires. The second sentence is an interesting standalone fact, but it is not one of the two sides of the win-win situation. Eliminate.

Option (4): 'The convergent evolution of the eye still blows my mind.' AND 'Although octopus eyes resemble those of vertebrates, the visual system in the brain does not.'

Tag: Correct Answer. This is the only pair that gives you both sides of the win-win in a single coordinated comparison. The first sentence captures a striking similarity: convergent evolution producing remarkably similar eyes. The second sentence captures an equally striking difference: the visual processing system in the brain is profoundly unlike its vertebrate counterpart. One pair. One similarity. One difference. Both involve the same biological feature — vision — making the contrast even sharper. That is exactly what the win-win logic requires.

Question 4 • *Framing 4 — Scoped EXCEPT*

All of the following can be inferred about cephalopod evolution from the passage EXCEPT:

(1) the loss of protective shells caused the cephalopod lineage to evolve larger brains as a survival adaptation.

(2) the high intelligence observed in modern cephalopods like octopuses is enabled by their unusually large brains.

(3) the cephalopod lineage diverged into two main branches: nautiluses on one side, and cuttlefish, squid, and octopuses on the other.

(4) cephalopods and vertebrates have not shared a common ancestor for over half a billion years.

Correct Answer: (1)

The Demand

This is a scoped EXCEPT. The scope is cephalopod evolution. Three options will be things that can genuinely be inferred from the passage about cephalopod evolution. One will not. For EXCEPT questions, the approach is: find the one that breaks. The break might be a lie, an alien idea, or a false causal claim the passage does not support. Read each option carefully and run it against paragraph three, where most of the evolutionary information lives.

Anticipate

The passage describes cephalopod evolution in paragraph three: they diverged from nautiluses, lost their shells, and evolved large brains. The key causal claim to watch: the passage uses the conjunction 'and' to connect shell loss and brain growth. 'And' indicates sequence, not causation. Any option that converts this into a causal relationship is breaking the passage.

Kill the Options

Option (1): the loss of protective shells caused the cephalopod lineage to evolve larger brains as a survival adaptation.

Tag: Correct Answer — False Causal Claim. Paragraph three says: 'They then lost their protective shells and evolved brains that are uniquely large among invertebrates.' The passage uses the conjunction 'and'. Losing shells happened, and evolving large brains happened. The passage does not say that losing shells caused brain growth, and certainly does not say that larger brains were a survival adaptation to compensate for shell loss. That is a causal chain the student is invited to construct, but the passage never makes it. Two events in sequence, presented as if one caused the other. Classic false causal inference.

Option (2): the high intelligence observed in modern cephalopods like octopuses is enabled by their unusually large brains.

Tag: True — Eliminate. Paragraph three states: 'These brains bestow the soft-bodied cephalopods with high intelligence.' 'Bestow' is a causal word — the brains give them intelligence. The passage also lists what that intelligence produces: memory, tool use, problem-solving. This causal claim is explicitly supported. Eliminate.

Option (3): the cephalopod lineage diverged into two main branches: nautiluses on one side, and cuttlefish, squid, and octopuses on the other.

Tag: True — Eliminate. Paragraph three says that around 400 million years ago, cuttlefish, squid and octopuses diverged from the only other living cephalopods — the nautiluses. Option (3) is a faithful paraphrase of that split. Eliminate.

Option (4): cephalopods and vertebrates have not shared a common ancestor for over half a billion years.

Tag: True — Eliminate. Paragraph two says cephalopods have evolved independently from the vertebrate lineage for more than 600 million years. 600 million is more than half a billion (500 million). 'Not shared a common ancestor for over half a billion years' is a valid restatement of having evolved independently for more than 600 million years. The maths works. Eliminate.

OVERALL LEARNING

Four questions. Four framings. One method. What this lesson has shown you is that the variety in Open Inference question framings is real, but it does not change the underlying logic of how you solve the question. You still doodle, you still name the demand, you still take options to the doodle, you still verify when uncertain. What does change is the **anticipate step** — and the anticipate step is now more important than ever.

In Question 1, the **multi-source synthesis** framing required you to hold both sources simultaneously, understand what each was saying on its own terms, and find the option that combined them faithfully without overstating either. The critical discipline: honour the epistemic hedging. If Niell says 'we have no idea' and Laurent says 'might', the answer cannot say 'will'.

In Question 2, the **odd-pair-out** framing required you to classify the relationships within each pair and find the one that was categorically different in kind from the others. The word 'nature' in the demand was the operative word. You are classifying relationship-type, not importance or frequency. One pair was similar; three were different. The odd one out was the similar one.

In Question 3, the **pair-selection** framing required you to understand the specific idea named in the demand well enough to identify which two sentences from the passage together captured both sides of that idea. The win-win logic is: similarity is valuable, difference is also valuable. Option (4) was the only pair that gave you both sides. The trap was choosing a pair that gave you only one side of a two-sided idea.

In Question 4, the **scoped EXCEPT** framing required you to test each option against the passage on the named topic and identify the one that broke. The break in option (1) was a false causal claim: the passage described two events using the conjunction 'and', and the option converted that into a causal relationship. **Sequence in time is not the same as causation.** That is a trap the CAT has used before and will use again.

The broader takeaway is this: no list of Open Inference question framings is exhaustive. CAT setters can and will invent new presentations. The protection against that is not memorising question types. The protection is a strong doodle, a careful reading of the demand, and the discipline to take each option back to the passage rather than to your instinct about what sounds right. **Doodle better. Anticipate correctly. Trust the passage.**

LESSON HANDOUT

Module: Know the Question Stems – RC
Lesson 3.7.1: Specific Function Questions – 1

WHERE WE ARE

Module 3 has taken you through the full landscape of RC question types. You have done Global questions — main idea, primary purpose, title — and you have spent significant time on Local Closed questions, understanding how to locate a specific pointer in the stem, read the relevant section of the passage, anticipate the answer before looking at the options, and eliminate wrong choices using the STEALS framework. You have also covered Inference questions — closed and open — and you now know that the word 'inferred' rarely asks for elaborate deductive reasoning. It almost always means 'true.'

This lesson introduces **Specific Function questions**. In terms of what the question is asking you to do, this is a distinct question type with its own logic. But in terms of how you solve it, you will find that the same discipline you have built — locate, read the neighbourhood, anticipate, eliminate — applies here as well. What is new is not the method. What is new is the trap. And this lesson is dedicated almost entirely to explaining that one trap, because it is the trap that catches the overwhelming majority of students on this question type every single time.

WHAT IS A SPECIFIC FUNCTION QUESTION?

The question type is simpler to understand than its name might suggest. A Specific Function question asks you one thing: **why did the author put this particular thing here?** That is it. That is the whole question type.

The 'particular thing' will be something specific from the passage — an example, a piece of evidence, a study, a metaphor, an analogy, a named reference, a specific line or discussion. The question stem will point you to it by name: 'the author mentions the Opies' documentation', 'the author refers to the concept of junk playgrounds', 'through the statement "and thousands more, surely, have been anointed without adult guidance"'. It is always anchored. It always has a specific location in the passage. That is what makes it a closed question.

Because it is anchored and closed, it is, in principle, a very scoreable question type. You know exactly where to look. The answer is always nearby. The passage will not hide it from you. The only thing standing between you and the correct answer is the trap — and the trap is consistent, predictable, and dismantleable once you understand it.

THE FOUR SUB-TYPES

Specific Function questions appear in four shapes, depending on what the 'device' is that the question is pointing at.

Purpose of an Example or Evidence — 44% of Specific Function questions

This is by far the most frequent sub-type. The author uses a case study, an observation, a historical event, a data point, or a named instance. The question asks why. Examples from past CAT papers: the Opies' documentation of post-war British children, the 1968 study, the Hadza community, the Uber example, the artifact dating.

Purpose of a Metaphor or Analogy — 21%

The author reaches for a comparison to make an abstract idea concrete. The question asks what that comparison is doing. Examples include: a mall described as an ecosystem, a dog walker, fuel use in a car, blankets as a device. This sub-type sometimes overlaps with meaning-in-context questions.

Purpose of a Specific Line or Discussion — 18%

A particular sentence, a particular framing, a section the author flagged explicitly. The question says: through this statement, the author seeks to — and you have to identify the function of that line in the argument.

Purpose of a Reference — 18%

The author name-drops someone or something. Galbraith. William Morris. The ancient Greeks. The Davos elite. The question asks what work that reference is doing. Why is this name here? What claim is it being used to support? All four sub-types share one underlying demand: *why did the author put this here? What role does it play in the larger argument?* The surface form of the question changes. The logical demand does not.

FREQUENCY AND SETTER PATTERNS

Specific Function questions account for approximately 8% of all RC questions across CAT 2017–2025. This is significant enough to warrant dedicated preparation, but the question type is heavily setter-dependent. IIM Lucknow set CAT in 2017 and used Specific Function questions for 25% of their RC paper. When they returned in 2023, that figure came back at 15%. IIM Ahmedabad and IIM Bangalore used them at 4% and 0% respectively. IIM Kozhikode used them at 8% in 2019 and 8% again in 2025. IIM Calcutta used them at 6% in 2018 and 4% in 2024. IIM Indore, in 2020, used them at 0%. The pattern is clear: this question type rewards preparation when it comes, and when it comes from certain setters, it comes in volume.

THE TWO LAYERS: SERVANT AND MASTER

This is the conceptual framework that unlocks Specific Function questions. Every Specific Function question is built on two layers, and the question tests whether you can tell them apart.

Layer 1 — The Device (the Servant)

The actual thing the question stem is pointing at. The Opies' study. Sørensen's junk playgrounds. The 1968 mortality data. The Welsh language. Whatever specific element has been named — that is the servant. It exists in the passage to do a job.

Layer 2 — The Claim (the Master)

The larger point the author is making. The claim that the device was brought in to support, illustrate, prove, or deepen. The master is what the passage is actually arguing. The servant exists only to serve the master.

The question always points at Layer 1. The correct answer is always Layer 2.

Read that again. The question points at the servant. The answer is about the master. The moment you understand this, the entire question type makes sense. The author did not include the Opies' documentation because the paper is about the Opies. The author did not include the Sweden statistics because the passage is about Sweden. These things are present because they are serving a claim the author wants to make. Your job is to identify that claim.

Think of it this way. If a passage claims that alcohol is bad for health, and then cites a study to support that, and then asks: 'why is this study mentioned?' — the answer is not 'to describe the findings of the study.' The answer is 'to support the claim that alcohol is bad for health.' The study is the servant. The anti-alcohol claim is the master. This distinction is the entire question type.

THE TRAP: WHAT vs. WHY

The distortion profile for Specific Function questions is dominated by one category: **Sidetrack-Truth**. Across wrong options in this question type, roughly 60% are Sidetracks, and of those, approximately 57 percentage points are Sidetrack-Truth. The option states something that is genuinely true about the passage. It lifts real passage content. It accurately describes something the passage contains. And it is wrong.

Here is why. The option answers the wrong question. It tells you ***what*** the element says rather than ***why*** the element is there. It describes the content of the device rather than the function of the device. The setter has built the most tempting wrong option possible: the option that is factually correct but categorically incorrect as an answer to a function question.

This is what the lesson calls the **What-Trap**. A wrong option falls into the What-Trap when it describes what the element says — captures its content, its findings, its surface meaning — rather than what the element does in the larger argument. The right answer is a **Why-Answer**: it captures the function the element performs, the claim it is being used to support, the job it has been given in the passage.

The remaining wrong options are distributed across Alien Idea (25%), where the option introduces a concept not present in the passage at all; Lie (10%), where the option directly contradicts the element's actual role; and Scope and Tone/Extreme, which together account for about 5%. The What-Trap via Sidetrack-Truth is the headline.

THE METHOD

The solving approach for Specific Function questions has three steps, followed by one final check before committing to an answer.

Step 1: Locate the element

The stem points you to something specific. Find it in the passage. Because this is a closed question, it is anchored — it has a precise location. You do not need to search the whole passage.

Step 2: Read its neighbourhood

Two or three sentences before and after the element. The function of the element almost always lives in the neighbourhood rather than inside the element itself. The claim the element is serving will usually appear just before it — as the point it is being introduced to support — or just after it, as the conclusion the author draws from it. Read with this in mind.

Step 3: Ask what claim this is supporting

What was the author trying to establish when they introduced this element? Why, at this exact moment in the argument, did the author feel the need to bring in this example, reference, line, or metaphor? The answer to that question is the answer to the question.

The check before you commit: did the question ask WHAT or WHY?

Before you confirm your answer choice, ask yourself: am I picking an option because it describes the element accurately, or because it captures what the element is doing in the argument? If the option you are leaning towards is accurate about the element but is describing its content rather than its function, it is the What-Trap. Let it go.

One more thing worth noting: in many cases, the correct answer to a Specific Function question will be your doodle — the main idea of the paragraph or the key claim you noted when reading. The servant serves the master, and the master is usually exactly the kind of thing you would have captured in your doodle. This is why good reading protects you even before you see the question.

THE PASSAGE

Source: *Aeon Magazine*

Stats: ~280 words | 2 paragraphs | Multiple sentence types | Flesch–Kincaid Grade: approx. 11–12

Reading Difficulty: Accessible expository prose. Concrete examples and statistics. The challenge is not decoding the language — it is tracking the argument structure: evidence first, then conclusion in Paragraph 1; conclusion first, then evidence in Paragraph 2.

¶1 When the folklorists Iona and Peter Opie documented the lives of children in post-war Britain, they noticed that kids liked to roam in packs through bomb sites, where they would play hide-and-seek and roast potatoes over campfires. In Denmark in the 1930s, the landscape architect Carl Theodor Sørensen was amazed when he realised that local children preferred to play in derelict construction sites rather than the parks he had carefully designed for them. In response, he developed the concept of 'junk playgrounds'. These structures eschew adult-designed swings and slides, allowing kids to guide their own activities instead. They were later adopted by the British and renamed 'adventure playgrounds', hundreds of which have been built since Sørensen's time. And thousands more, surely, have been anointed without adult guidance.

¶2 This evidence tells us something important about human development: children want to explore together and build independent peer cultures that are partially distinct from the ways of adults. Yet since the early 1970s, many Western countries have increasingly limited the social and physical independence of children. From 1970 to 1990, for instance, independent mobility starkly dropped for children living in England and Sweden. According to research by the Policy Studies Institute, roughly 63 to 94 per cent of English children were permitted to travel to places other than school alone in 1971, but by 1990 that count had dropped to 37 per cent. Similarly, as of 1981, 60 per cent of Swedish children were allowed to go to the library alone, but in 2009 the same privilege was granted to only 15 per cent.

READING THE PASSAGE — PARAGRAPH BY PARAGRAPH

The passage is a short extract from a piece on children's independence. It is not difficult prose — the vocabulary is accessible, the examples are concrete, and the logic is direct. What matters here is argument structure. Paragraph 1 gives you evidence first and holds the conclusion to the start of Paragraph 2. Paragraph 2 then switches direction: conclusion stated immediately, followed by supporting statistics. Reading this correctly means seeing both paragraphs as one continuous argument rather than two separate units.

Paragraph 1 — Children Naturally Build Independent Play Cultures

The paragraph opens with two examples — the Opies in post-war Britain, Sørensen in 1930s Denmark — and both point at the same observation: left to their own devices, children consistently gravitate towards unstructured, self-directed environments rather than the carefully designed ones that adults provide. The Opies noticed kids roaming bomb sites in packs. Sørensen was 'amazed' — note that word: it signals genuine surprise — that children bypassed his professional parks in favour of abandoned construction sites. Sørensen's *response* to his own amazement is itself significant: instead of redesigning the parks, he developed the concept of 'junk playgrounds' — spaces that explicitly remove adult-designed structures and let children guide their own play. The British later adopted and renamed them 'adventure playgrounds.' And then the paragraph ends with a quiet but important observation: thousands more have been 'anointed without adult guidance.' That phrase matters. It says that beyond the formally built adventure playgrounds, countless more have been created spontaneously by children, with no adult involvement at all. The whole paragraph is evidence building towards one conclusion — which will only be stated when Paragraph 2 begins.

Doodle: *Children naturally build independent play cultures, separate from adult design.*

Paragraph 2 — Yet Western Countries Have Steadily Restricted Children's Independence

The paragraph opens with *This evidence tells us* — a phrase that retrospectively names everything in Paragraph 1 as evidence and then delivers the conclusion it was all leading to: children want to explore together and build independent peer cultures partially distinct from adult ways. The word **Yet** immediately follows, announcing the pivot. The first paragraph established that children naturally seek independence. The second paragraph is about to tell you that the world has been moving in the opposite direction. The claim arrives immediately: since the early 1970s, many Western countries have increasingly limited the social and physical independence of children. The rest of the paragraph is evidence for that claim — the England and Sweden statistics. Note the structure: conclusion first, evidence after. Exactly the reverse of Paragraph 1. Both paragraphs are doing the same work, but in opposite directions. This structural awareness is what lets you see the argument clearly enough to answer function questions correctly.

Doodle: *Since the 1970s, Western countries have increasingly limited children's independence.*

THE QUESTIONS

Question 1 · *Specific Function — Purpose of an Example*

The author mentions the Opies' documentation of post-war British children to —

(1) show that children build their own play cultures, partially different from adults.

(2) describe how children in post-war Britain roamed bomb sites and played hide-and-seek.

Correct Answer: (1)

Type

*Specific Function — Purpose of an Example. The stem asks **why** the author mentions the Opies. The 'to —' framing is the classic Specific Function marker.*

The Demand

The stem is asking why the Opies are in the passage. Not what they observed. Not what they documented. Why they are there. The moment you see 'the author mentions X to —' you know the question is asking for the function, not the content.

Relevant Passage Logic

The Opies appear in the first sentence of Paragraph 1. Their observation flows into the Sørensen example, and both flow into the conclusion that opens Paragraph 2: 'This evidence tells us something important about human development: children want to explore together and build independent peer cultures that are partially distinct from the ways of adults.' That sentence is the master. The Opies are one of several servants helping to build it.

Anticipate

Before going to the options: why are the Opies here? Because their observation is one piece of evidence that children naturally seek independent, self-directed play rather than adult-designed environments. The correct answer should say something close to: the Opies are there to support the claim that children build independent play cultures distinct from adults.

Kill the Options

Option (1): show that children build their own play cultures, partially different from adults.
Tag: *Correct Answer.* This captures the master, not the servant. The Opies are being used to establish exactly this claim — that children want to build independent peer cultures partially distinct from adult ways. Option (1) is pointing at Layer 2. Every word is earned.

Option (2): describe how children in post-war Britain roamed bomb sites and played hide-and-seek.
Tag: *S — Sidetrack (Truth / What-Trap).* This is exactly the trap. Every word in option (2) is factually accurate. The Opies did document children roaming bomb sites. Children did play hide-and-seek. This is real passage content, faithfully reproduced. And it is completely wrong as an answer to a function question. Option (2) is telling you what the Opies documented. The question is asking why the author brought the Opies in. The option describes the servant. The question asks about the master. Do not fall for it.

Question 2 · *Specific Function — Purpose of an Example*

The author refers to Carl Theodor Sørensen and his concept of 'junk playgrounds' in order to —

(1) explain why Sørensen developed a new concept to differentiate from the structured playgrounds that children were avoiding.

(2) highlight that children prefer to direct their own play rather than rely on environments designed for them by adults.

Correct Answer: (2)

Type

*Specific Function — Purpose of an Example. Same structure as Question 1. The stem is asking why the **author** referred to Sørensen, not why Sørensen did what he did.*

The Demand

Why is Sørensen here? Not who was he, not what he designed, not what his architectural philosophy was. The passage is not about Sørensen. Sørensen is a device. The question is pointing at the device and asking what the device is doing.

Relevant Passage Logic

Sørensen is in Paragraph 1. He was amazed that children preferred derelict construction sites to his carefully designed parks — and his response was to develop junk playgrounds, spaces that remove adult-designed structures and allow children to guide their own play. This observation and response feed directly into the paragraph's conclusion: children want to build independent peer cultures distinct from adult ways. Sørensen is being used to make exactly that point.

Anticipate

The correct answer should say: Sørensen is there to show that children prefer self-directed play over adult-designed environments. That is the claim the Sørensen example is supporting.

Kill the Options

Option (1): explain why Sørensen developed a new concept to differentiate from the structured playgrounds that children were avoiding.

Tag: *S — Sidetrack (What-Trap).* This option is answering the question: why did Sørensen develop junk playgrounds? That is a completely different question from: why did the author refer to Sørensen? The question is asking about the author's purpose. Option (1) is answering Sørensen's purpose. It is true as a description of Sørensen's motivation. It is wrong as an explanation of why the author brought Sørensen into this passage. The servant's biography is not the same as the servant's job description.

Option (2): highlight that children prefer to direct their own play rather than rely on environments designed for them by adults.

Tag: *Correct Answer.* This is the master. Children prefer to direct their own play. Sørensen's story is one of the pieces of evidence that builds this claim. Option (2) correctly captures what the Sørensen reference is doing in the argument. The word 'highlight' is exactly the right verb for a function answer — it signals that the element is being used to make a point, not to describe itself.

Question 3 • *Specific Function — Purpose of a Specific Line*

Through the statement — "And thousands more, surely, have been anointed without adult guidance" — the author seeks to:

(1) emphasise that children's instinct to create their own play environments operates on a far larger scale than any formal, adult-led effort to provide for it.

(2) highlight that thousands of adventure playgrounds have come into being informally, without adult involvement, beyond the hundreds officially built since Sørensen's time.

Correct Answer: (1)

Type

*Specific Function — Purpose of a Specific Line. The stem points at an exact sentence and asks: what is the author **doing** with this line? The phrase 'the author seeks to' is the function marker.*

The Demand

The stem is pointing at the closing sentence of Paragraph 1 and asking what it is doing. What is this line's job in the argument?

Relevant Passage Logic

The line appears at the very end of Paragraph 1: 'And thousands more, surely, have been anointed without adult guidance.' Read it carefully. It is saying that beyond the hundreds of formally built adventure playgrounds, thousands more have been created informally by children themselves — not designed, not commissioned, not supervised. The word 'surely' is also important: it signals the author's confidence that this is true, that the children's instinct to do this is so strong that you can count on it happening everywhere. The line is capping the paragraph's argument by pushing it to its fullest extent: children will always do this. Whatever formal structures you provide, the instinct operates far beyond them.

Anticipate

The line is there to show that children's drive to create their own independent play cultures is not limited to what adults build for them — it operates spontaneously, at a scale that dwarfs formal provision. The correct answer should capture that idea: the instinct is bigger than any adult effort to accommodate it.

Kill the Options

Option (1): emphasise that children's instinct to create their own play environments operates on a far larger scale than any formal, adult-led effort to provide for it.
Tag: *Correct Answer.* This captures the why precisely. The line exists to make the point that children's independent play instinct is enormous — it produces thousands of informal spaces beyond the hundreds that adults formally built. The comparison between informal scale and formal provision is exactly the point. Option (1) is the master.

Option (2): highlight that thousands of adventure playgrounds have come into being informally, without adult involvement, beyond the hundreds officially built since Sørensen's time.
Tag: *S — Sidetrack (What-Trap).* This is the most dangerous wrong option in this lesson. Read it carefully. It is factually accurate — it is describing exactly what the sentence says. Thousands of playgrounds have been anointed informally. This is true. But notice what option (2) is missing: the so what. It is describing the content of the statement — the what — without capturing the function — the why. The sentence is not there simply to note that informal playgrounds exist. It is there to emphasise the scale of children's autonomous instinct versus the comparatively limited reach of adult provision. Option (2) describes the servant. Option (1) identifies the master. Classic What-Trap.

Question 4 · *Specific Function — Purpose of Evidence*

The author mentions the studies in paragraph 2 in order to —

(1) show that the freedom of children to move around on their own dropped sharply in England and Sweden over those years.

(2) highlight that many Western societies have steadily reduced the social and physical independence children are allowed.

Correct Answer: (2)

Type

Specific Function — Purpose of Evidence. The England and Sweden data from the Policy Studies Institute are the 'studies' in question. The stem is asking why this data is in the passage. Same method, different device.

The Demand

The studies in Paragraph 2 are the Policy Studies Institute data on England and the Swedish library statistics. The question is asking why these data points are here. What are they doing in this passage?

Relevant Passage Logic

Paragraph 2 opens with a claim: since the early 1970s, many Western countries have increasingly limited the social and physical independence of children. The phrase 'for instance' follows shortly after, signalling that the England and Sweden data are being brought in as examples of this general claim. The studies are the evidence. The claim is that Western countries broadly have been restricting children's independence. The data from England and Sweden are there to make that general claim concrete.

Anticipate

The correct answer should say: the studies are there to support the claim that Western countries have restricted children's independence. Not to report the numbers. Not to tell you about England or Sweden specifically.

Kill the Options

Option (1): show that the freedom of children to move around on their own dropped sharply in England and Sweden over those years.

Tag: *S — Sidetrack (What-Trap).* A faithful description of what the data shows. Independent mobility did drop sharply in England and Sweden. The figures confirm exactly this. But option (1) is describing the findings of the studies — their content, their what. It is answering: what do the studies show? The question is: why are the studies here? The England-and-Sweden specificity is the giveaway. The passage is not about England and Sweden. It is about Western countries generally. England and Sweden are the examples. The claim is broader. Option (1) misidentifies the servant as the master.

Option (2): highlight that many Western societies have steadily reduced the social and physical independence children are allowed.

Tag: *Correct Answer.* This is precisely the claim that the paragraph opens with and that the studies are there to support. Option (2) correctly moves from the specific (England, Sweden) to the general (many Western societies), which is exactly what the author's argument is doing. The studies are servants to this broader master claim. Every word is earned.

OVERALL LEARNING

Four questions. One question type. One trap. The trap appeared in every single question, and it looked different each time — different passage content, different specific elements, different wording — but it was structurally identical every time. An option that accurately described the servant. An option that identified the master. The What-Trap versus the Why-Answer.

The central learning of this lesson: a Specific Function question is a closed question with two layers. The question always points at **Layer 1** — the device, the servant, the specific element. The correct answer is always **Layer 2** — the claim, the master, the larger point the element was introduced to serve. When you see a Specific Function stem, your single most important move is to locate the element, read its neighbourhood, and ask: what claim is this supporting? Not: what does this say? What does this ***do?***

The Sidetrack-Truth wrong option — the What-Trap — will be in approximately 57% of Specific Function questions you encounter. It will be factually correct. It will use real passage content. It will feel like a safe answer. The tell is always the same: it is describing the element rather than explaining the element's function. Train yourself to ask, before committing to any option: *is this answering what the element says, or why the element is there?*

Notice also that in this lesson, the correct answer was always close to the doodle — the main idea of the paragraph, the key claim the author was building. The reason is structural: the servant always serves the master, and the master is always the point you would have noted in your doodle. Students who read actively and doodle well will often find that Specific Function questions are answerable before they even look at the options. The claim is already there in their notes. This question type rewards good reading with easy marks.

Carry this into the next lesson and into every practice set you attempt from here: when the question says 'in order to' or 'the author mentions X to' or 'the author refers to X' — that is a function question. Do not describe the element. Find the master it serves.

LESSON HANDOUT

Module: Know the Question Stems – RC

Lesson 3.7.2: Specific Function Questions – 2

WHERE WE ARE

The previous lesson introduced Specific Function questions as a distinct question type built on two layers: the device (the servant) and the claim (the master). You understood the core discipline — the question always points at Layer 1, the answer is always Layer 2 — and you practised it on a two-paragraph passage. The What-Trap was named, the Why-Answer was named, and the three-step method was set down: locate the element, read its neighbourhood, ask what claim this is supporting.

This lesson applies that discipline on a full passage. Six paragraphs. Four devices the author leaned on across the argument. Each question points at a different kind of device — a reference, a specific line, another reference, an example — and in each case the trap is structurally identical even though the surface content is completely different. The lesson's purpose is to make the discipline automatic: not something you remember when you see the question type, but something that fires the moment you see the stem's function marker.

One pedagogical point before the passage. Because this is a Specific Function lesson, there is a temptation to read differently — to slow down on examples and references, to annotate devices as you go, to treat the passage as a map of answerable elements. Resist this. Your reading should be exactly the same as it always is: doodle the main idea of each paragraph, track the argument, move forward. The doodle you build through ordinary, consistent reading is the instrument that answers Specific Function questions. The claim that each device serves is almost always your doodle.

RECAP FROM LESSON 3.7.1

Two ideas to keep close as you walk into this lesson.

The Two Layers

Every Specific Function question has a device (the servant) and a claim (the master). The question points at Layer 1. The correct answer is always Layer 2. The What-Trap — a wrong option that describes the device rather than explaining its function — accounts for roughly 57% of all wrong options in this question type. It will be present in every question in this lesson. Every time.

The Three-Step Method

Step 1: Locate the element. The stem points to it — find it in the passage. Step 2: Read its neighbourhood. Two or three sentences before and after. The claim the element is serving will be there. Step 3: Ask what claim this is supporting. What was the author trying to establish at this point in the argument? The answer to that question is your anticipated answer. The check before committing: did the stem ask WHAT or WHY?

THE PASSAGE

Source: *'We'll soon find out what is truly special about human writing'* — James O'Sullivan, *Psyche*

Stats: 503 words | 21 sentences | 24 avg. words per sentence | Flesch–Kincaid Grade: 13.8

Reading Difficulty: Grade 13.8 — serious essay prose. Long, subordinate-clause-heavy sentences. The argument is layered and cumulative: each paragraph builds on the last. Do not try to decode every clause. Track the move each paragraph is making.

¶1 In the mid-15th century, when Johannes Gutenberg began experimenting with movable type, the scribes who had spent their lives copying manuscripts by hand could not have known they were witnessing the end of their profession. The texts maintained a deceptive continuity, circulating the same liturgies and legal canons that had always been reproduced, possibly camouflaging the massive shift that was occurring in the mechanics of cultural production. . . . We, looking back, can see what they couldn't: that the revolution was invisible in the output – it lived entirely in the means.

¶2 Nearly six centuries later, we find ourselves at another such juncture. Large language models (LLMs) can produce prose that is, by most functional measures, indistinguishable from competent human writing. . . .

¶3 Writing has always been understood as a trace of human thought; when we read, we assume that behind the words lies. . .a person who stands accountable for their claims. . . . Generative AI disrupts this assumption, producing text that has no author in any meaningful sense, no one who meant it, no one who can be held responsible for it, and no one who was changed by the act of composing it. The words exist, but the covenant that once connected writer to reader has been severed.

¶4 Writing has weathered previous technological upheavals. . .but the threat this time is of a different kind. . . . [Handwriting's dominance ended] in the 1870s, when the first commercial typewriters came to market. Where handwriting had long been understood as an extension of the body, a kind of graphological fingerprint, the typed page was uniform, mechanical, depersonalised. Writers like Henry James and Mark Twain, who were among the first to compose on typewriters, reported that the machine changed not just how their prose looked but how it felt to produce it. The clatter of keys imposed a different rhythm and a different relationship to revision. Something was lost; something else was gained. . . .

¶5 Generative AI represents a rupture of a different order, because, where previous technologies changed how writing was produced or distributed, LLMs change what writing is. . . . Human writing is only partly concerned with the production of words; more essential to its essence is the assumption of responsibility for those words. . . . Large language models cannot enter into the implicit contract that says: here is a mind engaging with a problem, here is a person who cares about getting it right. . . .

¶6 The future of writing may look less like the frictionless content economy of the recent past and more like the older, slower forms of correspondence and publication that preceded it. Letters, essays, criticism, investigative journalism, genres where the identity of the writer matters, where readers seek out particular voices and measure what is written against what has been written before. . . . Such forms cannot be automated without losing what makes them valuable, because they are, by their nature, resistant to scale. We might think of this moment, nearly six decades since the theorist and critic Roland Barthès proclaimed the death of the author, as a moment of revival, as the rebirth of the author.

READING THE PASSAGE — PARAGRAPH BY PARAGRAPH

The passage is a serious essay from Psyche — long sentences, academic register, a carefully scaffolded argument. The author, James O'Sullivan, is building towards a claim about what makes human writing irreplaceable in the age of AI. The argument is cumulative and moves in a specific direction: historical precedent (Paragraphs 1–4) followed by the key distinction (Paragraph 5) followed by the conclusion (Paragraph 6). Read each paragraph as one move in that progression.

Paragraph 1 — Gutenberg's Revolution Was Invisible in the Output

The paragraph opens with Gutenberg and the scribes of the mid-15th century. The scribes were copying manuscripts by hand when the printing press arrived. They did not know their profession was ending, because the output — the books and texts — continued to look the same. The same liturgies, the same legal canons. The revolution was happening in the means, not the output. That is the key phrase: the revolution was invisible in the output – it lived entirely in the means. This is not the main argument of the passage. It is a historical example being set up for a purpose — specifically, to establish a precedent that will be used to frame the AI moment in Paragraph 2.

Doodle: *Gutenberg's printing-press revolution was invisible in the output — it lived entirely in the means.*

Paragraph 2 — AI Is the New Such Juncture

The paragraph is very short but structurally pivotal. The phrase *another such juncture* does all the work: it explicitly connects the Gutenberg moment from Paragraph 1 to the present AI moment. LLMs can produce prose indistinguishable from competent human writing. The paragraph is announcing that we are in a comparable historical moment — a moment where, as with Gutenberg, the surface output may look the same even as something fundamental is changing.

Doodle: *AI is the new such juncture — LLMs produce prose indistinguishable from human writing.*

Paragraph 3 — AI Severs the Writer–Reader Covenant

The paragraph establishes what writing has always been assumed to be: a trace of human thought, with a person behind the words who is accountable for what they said. Generative AI disrupts that assumption. The key formulation is the three-part list: no one who meant it, no one who can be held responsible for it, and no one who was changed by the act of composing it. These three absences define what AI text lacks. The paragraph ends with the covenant metaphor: writing once connected writer to reader through an implicit bond of authorship. That covenant has been severed. This is the argument's emotional and conceptual centre.

Doodle: *AI severs the writer–reader covenant — the text has no author, no accountability, no stake.*

Paragraph 4 — Typewriters Shifted the Process; Loss Was Balanced by Gain

The paragraph opens a historical comparison: writing has survived previous technological upheavals. The typewriter arrived in the 1870s, transforming handwriting — which had been understood as a bodily extension, a graphological fingerprint — into uniform, mechanical, depersonalised type. Henry James and Mark Twain, early adopters of the typewriter, reported that the machine changed not just how their prose looked but how it felt to produce it. The rhythm changed. The relationship to revision changed. Something was lost; something was gained. The paragraph is building a contrast that Paragraph 5 will complete: the typewriter shifted how writing was produced, but AI changes something of a different order entirely.

Doodle: *Typewriter changed writing's process; something was lost but something was gained — unlike AI.*

Paragraph 5 — AI Changes What Writing Is

The paragraph makes the key distinction that the entire passage has been building towards. Previous technologies — including the typewriter — changed *how* writing was produced or distributed. LLMs change *what writing is*. Human writing is only partly about the production of words. More essential to its essence is the assumption of responsibility for those words. LLMs cannot enter into the implicit contract of human authorship — here is a mind engaging with a problem, here is a person who cares about getting it right. This is the passage's central claim, and it is explicitly marked as the conclusion of the historical argument in Paragraphs 1–4.

Doodle: *AI changes what writing is — not just how it is produced; it cannot assume responsibility for words.*

Paragraph 6 — Future Revives Identity-Anchored Writing

The final paragraph turns to the future. Writing will look less like the frictionless content economy and more like the older, slower forms — letters, essays, criticism, investigative journalism — where the identity of the writer matters, where readers seek out particular voices. These forms cannot be automated without losing what makes them valuable, because they are by nature resistant to scale. The paragraph closes by invoking Roland Barthès, who famously proclaimed the *'death of the author'* six decades ago. The author proposes that we may be witnessing the inverse: not the death but the rebirth of the author. Human authorship, precisely because AI cannot replicate it, may gain renewed value.

Doodle: *Future revives identity-anchored writing — the rebirth of the author as AI cannot replicate human authorship.*

THE QUESTIONS

Question 1 · *Specific Function — Purpose of a Reference — ¶4 — Henry James and Mark Twain*

The author's reference to Henry James and Mark Twain composing on early typewriters most directly serves to:

(1) set up a contrast between earlier shifts in writing and AI's qualitatively different kind of rupture.

(2) suggest that AI's disruption to writing almost mirrors the earlier technological shifts that writers have already weathered.

(3) express nostalgia for an earlier era when writers maintained a more personal relationship with their craft.

(4) illustrate the specific effects the typewriter had on the writing process of nineteenth-century literary authors.

Correct Answer: (1)

Type

Specific Function — Purpose of a Reference. The stem points at Henry James and Mark Twain and asks what work their mention is doing. The phrase *most directly serves to* is the function marker.

The Demand

Locate James and Twain in Paragraph 4. They appear as early adopters of the typewriter who reported that the machine changed not just how their prose looked but how it felt to produce it — the rhythm changed, the relationship to revision changed. Now ask: why does the author need this specific detail at this point in the argument? Paragraph 4 is establishing that previous technologies changed the process of writing. But Paragraph 5 will immediately argue that AI is categorically different — it changes what writing is, not merely how it is produced. James and Twain are there to concretise the typewriter transition and, more importantly, to set up the contrast that Paragraph 5 delivers.

Anticipate

The correct answer should say: James and Twain are there to build the contrast between earlier technological shifts — which changed the process — and AI's qualitatively different rupture. They are servants to the master claim that the threat this time is of a different kind.

Kill the Options

Option (1): set up a contrast between earlier shifts in writing and AI's qualitatively different kind of rupture.
Tag: *Correct Answer.* This is the master. James and Twain are being used to make the typewriter's impact on the process of writing concrete and vivid — precisely so that Paragraph 5 can then pivot and say: but AI is different. The contrast is the point. Option (1) captures the function, not just the content. Every word is earned.
inverted. This is a lie about the passage's argument. Eliminate.

Option (2): predict that future writing will return to the slower forms that preceded the digital content economy.
Tag: *S — Sidetrack (Truth).* This is a claim the passage does make — in the first half of Paragraph 6. The future of writing may look more like letters, essays, criticism, investigative journalism. But this is not what the Barthès reference is doing. The reference appears in the closing sentence, after the slower-forms point has already been made. Option (2) describes an earlier idea in the same paragraph, not the function of the specific reference the question is asking about. Precise location matters.

Option (3): emphasise that AI represents a rupture different from earlier shifts because it changes what writing fundamentally is.
Tag: *S — Sidetrack (Truth from elsewhere).* True, and arguably the passage's central claim. But this claim is made in Paragraph 5, not in connection with the Barthès reference. The question is asking why Barthès is there in Paragraph 6. Option (3) attributes to the Barthès reference a function that belongs to a different paragraph entirely. Wrong location, wrong function.

Option (4): signal that human authorship may gain renewed value because it is the one thing AI cannot replicate.
Tag: *Correct Answer.* This is the master. The Barthès 'death of the author' reference is invoked precisely to set up the rebirth — the reversal. By contrasting the Barthès moment with the present one, the author signals that human authorship, far from disappearing, may gain renewed importance. Option (4) captures the function of the reference exactly. It is why the reference is there, not what Barthès originally said. Every word is earned.

Question 4 · *Specific Function — Purpose of an Example — ¶1 — Gutenberg's Printing Press*

The author opens the passage with Gutenberg's printing press and the scribes of the 15th century in order to:

(1) highlight that scribes lost their profession when Gutenberg's printing press emerged in the 15th century.

(2) reassure readers that, like the printing press, AI will ultimately benefit how humans engage with writing.

(3) frame AI's emergence as another moment when a writing revolution may be invisible in its output.

(4) describe how texts produced by Gutenberg's printing press looked similar to those copied by scribes by hand.

Correct Answer: (3)

Type

Specific Function — Purpose of an Example. The Gutenberg-and-scribes example opens the entire passage. The stem asks *in order to* — the function marker. Note that the question is about the whole opening example, not a specific sentence within it.

The Demand

The Gutenberg example is in Paragraph 1. The scribes were copying manuscripts when the printing press arrived and did not know their profession was ending, because the output — the books and texts — continued to look the same. The revolution was invisible in the output; it lived in the means. Paragraph 2 then opens with 'another such juncture' and introduces AI. That connection is everything. The Gutenberg example exists to set up the AI moment: both are situations where a revolution in the means of production may be invisible in the output. The printing press is the historical precedent. AI is the present instance.

Anticipate

The correct answer should say: Gutenberg and the scribes are there to frame the AI moment as a comparable historical juncture — a moment when a revolution in writing may be invisible in the output. The example is the servant. The master is: here is the AI analogue of the Gutenberg moment.

Kill the Options

Option (1): highlight that scribes lost their profession when Gutenberg's printing press emerged in the 15th century.

Tag: *S — Sidetrack (What-Trap).* The passage does say the scribes could not have known they were witnessing the end of their profession. That is in the text. But the scribes losing their jobs is incidental — it is a detail that illustrates the scale of the shift, not the point of the example. The point is that the revolution was invisible in the output. Option (1) describes a detail from the example. The question asks for the function of the example. What, not why.

Option (2): reassure readers that, like the printing press, AI will ultimately benefit how humans engage with writing.

Tag: *S — Sidetrack (Alien / Tone Mismatch).* The passage does not reassure anyone. The author is not drawing a parallel to suggest AI will turn out fine like the printing press did. On the contrary, Paragraph 5 argues that AI is categorically different and more disruptive. The word 'reassure' is alien to the passage's tone and argument. The printing press parallel is used to establish the category of 'revolution invisible in the output' — not to comfort readers about AI's eventual benefits.

Option (3): frame AI's emergence as another moment when a writing revolution may be invisible in its output.

Tag: *Correct Answer.* This is the master. The Gutenberg example establishes the concept of a revolution invisible in the output. Paragraph 2 then explicitly flags AI as 'another such juncture.' Option (3) captures the function precisely: the printing press is there to frame — to set up the category — so that the AI moment can be understood through that frame. The word 'frame' is exactly the right verb. Every word is earned.

Option (4): describe how texts produced by Gutenberg's printing press looked similar to those copied by scribes by hand.

Tag: *S — Sidetrack (What-Trap).* Also factually accurate: the passage does say the texts maintained a deceptive continuity, circulating the same liturgies and legal canons. The output looked the same. But option (4) is, again, describing the content of the example rather than its function in the argument. The similarity of the output is the mechanism that makes the example work, not the purpose for which the example was brought in. What, not why.

OVERALL LEARNING

Four questions. Four devices. Four times the same trap. The What-Trap appeared in every question in this lesson, and in every question it wore different clothes. In Question 1, it appeared as option (4): a factually accurate description of what James and Twain reported. In Question 2, it appeared as options (1), (3), and (4) simultaneously — all true statements from the same paragraph, all describing the content of the line rather than its function. In Question 3, it appeared as option (2): a true claim from Paragraph 6, just not the one the Barthès reference was there to make. In Question 4, it appeared as options (1) and (4): real passage details, real passage language, not the purpose.

The structural lesson is this. The What-Trap is not easy to spot because it is not wrong about the passage. It is wrong about the **question.** The question is asking for the function. The What-Trap gives you the content. Every time you are unsure which option to pick in a Specific Function question, ask yourself: is this option telling me what the element *says*, or is it telling me what the element *does?* If it is telling you what it says, it is the trap. If it is telling you what it does — what master claim it is serving — it is the answer.

Notice also the range of devices this lesson covered: a reference to named literary figures (James and Twain), a specific quoted line (the three-part list), a reference to a named theorist (Barthès), and an opening historical example (Gutenberg). Four different devices, four different surface textures, one underlying discipline. The question points at the device. The answer is the claim.

One final observation from the lesson. In every question in this set, the correct answer was essentially the doodle of the paragraph containing the device, or the doodle of the paragraph immediately following it. This is not a coincidence. The claim that a device serves is the main point of the paragraph it appears in. If your doodle is sharp — if it captures the key idea of each paragraph rather than a loose summary of the surface — you will be able to anticipate the correct answer to a Specific Function question before you touch the options. The instrument is the doodle. Build it well.

LESSON HANDOUT

Module: Know the Question Stems – RC
Lesson 3.8.1: The Logical Questions – Argument & Assumptions

WHERE WE ARE

Modules 1 and 2 were about reading — what passages are, how to read them, how to doodle them, and how to hold an argument together long enough to answer questions about it. Module 3 has been about question types. You have worked through Global questions, Local questions — Closed and Open — Inference questions, and Specific Function questions. All of those question types sit inside the RC section and ask you to engage with the passage as a reading unit.

This lesson opens a different chapter within Module 3. The Reasoning Family — Assumption, Strengthen, and Weaken — is a set of question types that asks you not to read the passage but to evaluate an argument within it. These are logical questions, not reading-comprehension questions. They require you to do something the earlier question types never asked: identify the inferential gap between what is stated and what is concluded, and then decide whether a given option closes, widens, or destroys that gap.

This lesson covers Assumptions. The next two lessons will cover Weaken and Strengthen. The three are taught together because they are structurally the same question family. Understanding what an assumption is — really understanding it, not just memorising a definition — is the foundation for everything else in the Reasoning Family. This lesson builds that foundation.

THE REASONING FAMILY — FREQUENCY AND SETTER PATTERNS

Across CAT 2017–2025, there were 438 RC questions. Of those, 51 belonged to the Reasoning Family — Assumption, Strengthen, or Weaken combined. That is approximately 12% of all RC questions, or roughly 3–5 questions in a typical paper. The family is present in every paper, though the distribution across the three subtypes varies considerably.

Within the family, Weaken dominates. Of the 51 questions, 34 were Weaken questions (67%), 14 were Strengthen questions (27%), and only 3 were Assumption questions (6%). The assumption questions are almost negligible by count: one appeared in the 2017 paper set by IIM Lucknow, and two appeared in the 2025 paper set by IIM Kozhikode. The remaining seven years produced none.

The year-wise picture is instructive. IIM Lucknow's 2017 paper had no Weaken or Strengthen questions at all — just the one Assumption. IIM Calcutta set 6 Weaken questions in 2018 and 3 in 2024. IIM Kozhikode produced the largest haul in 2019 (11 reasoning questions: 8 Weaken, 3 Strengthen) and set a balanced spread again in 2025. IIM Ahmedabad (2021), IIM Bangalore (2022), and IIM Lucknow (2023) each had between 4 and 7 reasoning questions. IIM Indore, which is the expected setter for CAT 2026, set 5 Weaken and 1 Strengthen question in 2020 — no Assumptions.

What this tells you practically: Weaken and Strengthen are the priority within this family. Assumptions are rare, but the conceptual understanding of what an assumption is underpins your ability to answer Weaken and Strengthen questions correctly. You cannot isolate this lesson and skip it just because only 3 assumption questions have appeared in nine years.

WHY IS THIS A REASONING FAMILY?

The three question types — Assumption, Strengthen, Weaken — all operate on the same underlying structure: an argument. An argument is a claim supported by reasons. Before you can identify an assumption, strengthen a conclusion, or weaken one, you need to see the argument clearly. This means being able to separate the conclusion from the premises.

The Conclusion

The conclusion is the main claim the author is making. It is what the argument is trying to establish. It is not necessarily the last sentence of the paragraph. It is the point that all the evidence is being marshalled to support. In argument terms, it is the master. Think of it the way you think of the master in a Specific Function question: it is the thing everything else is there to serve.

The Premises

The premises are the reasons offered in support of the conclusion. They are the evidence, the justification, the data, the observations. They are the servants. In a properly constructed argument, the premises support the conclusion. In a flawed argument — which is what CAT typically gives you — the premises support the conclusion only if you fill in an unstated gap. That gap is the assumption.

Why Strengthen and Weaken Are in the Same Family

Think of the argument's logical force on a scale. An assumption is what you must accept for the argument to hold at all — it is the *necessary* support, the absolute minimum. If you negate it, the argument collapses entirely. A strengthener is something that adds additional support to the argument without being strictly necessary — it pushes the argument further towards certainty. A weakener is something that attacks the gap between the premises and the conclusion — it does not have to destroy the argument, but it makes it less convincing. All three operations work on the same structural joint: the link between the premises and the conclusion. That is why they are one family.

WHAT IS AN ASSUMPTION?

An assumption is a **necessary unstated condition** that must be true for the argument to hold. It is the bridge between the premise and the conclusion — the gap that has not been stated but that the argument depends on. If the assumption is false, the argument falls apart. If it is true, the argument can proceed.

One important correction before going further. Many courses teach students to identify assumptions as things that are 'hidden' or 'unstated.' This is a loose and sometimes misleading way to think about it. The better criterion is necessity. Ask not 'Is this stated?' but 'Is this necessary?' An assumption can sometimes appear close to something the passage has said — and yet it remains an assumption because it is the logical support the argument requires. The test is always: if this is false, does the argument collapse? If yes, it is an assumption.

The negation test is the most reliable tool you have. If you negate an option and the conclusion is destroyed, that option is an assumption. If you negate an option and the argument is merely weakened but not destroyed, the option is a strengthener, not an assumption. If negating it makes no difference to the argument, the option is irrelevant.

SIX SHORT ARGUMENTS — NAMING THE GAP

The six arguments below were used in the lesson to build the concept of assumption from the ground up. Read each argument, identify the conclusion and the premise, and then find the gap — the necessary unstated support that connects the two.

Argument 1 — Moby Dick

Premise: *Moby Dick is a whale.*
Conclusion: *So Moby Dick is a mammal.*

Gap / Assumption: *Whales are mammals.*

This is the cleanest possible example of an assumption. The premise gives you one fact. The conclusion draws a different fact from it. The bridge between 'whale' and 'mammal' is nowhere stated in the argument. It is the assumption. If whales were not mammals, the argument would be invalid. The assumption must be true for the conclusion to follow from the premise. This is the basic structure of every assumption in every CAT question.

Argument 2 — Fail Grade

Premise: *Giving students a fail grade will damage their self-confidence.*
Conclusion: *Therefore, we should not fail students.*

Gap / Assumption: *We should not do things that damage students' self-confidence.*

The premise gives you a consequence: fail grades damage self-confidence. The conclusion is that we should not fail students. The gap is the value judgement that connects the two: *damaging self-confidence is a sufficient reason not to do something*. Without that assumption, the argument does not move. You can accept the premise entirely and still reject the conclusion — which is exactly what you would do if you are evaluating arguments carefully. The lesson here: accepting a premise does not mean accepting the conclusion. The gap between them is the work you have to do.

Argument 3 — Smoking Pot

Premise: *It does not harm anyone.*
Conclusion: *It should not be illegal for adults to smoke pot.*

Gap / Assumption: *Things that do not harm anyone should not be illegal.*

The premise claims no harm. The conclusion claims it should be legal. The bridge is the assumption that *harm to others is the only legitimate basis for making something illegal.* If there are other reasons for illegality beyond harm — moral, social, religious, cultural — the argument does not hold. Notice that you can attack this argument entirely without disputing the premise. You accept that it does not harm anyone, and you still reject the conclusion by questioning the assumption. This is the most useful skill in argument evaluation: cut the link, not the premise.

Argument 4 — Mobile Phone in Lectures

Premise: *Other students do it all the time.*
Conclusion: *There is nothing wrong with talking on a mobile phone during lectures.*

Gap / Assumption: *If others do something, then it is not wrong.*

The argument is structurally clear even though it is logically weak. The premise asserts prevalence. The conclusion asserts permissibility. The gap is the assumption that frequency of behaviour establishes its moral acceptability — that something done by many cannot be wrong. This is a formally invalid assumption (common behaviour has no necessary bearing on ethical status), but it is the assumption nonetheless. The lesson is important: your job is not to evaluate whether the assumption is a good one. Your job is to identify what the argument needs to be true. The assumption here is both necessary and, by most ethical standards, false.

Argument 5 — Abortion

Premise: *Killing an innocent person is wrong.*
Conclusion: *Therefore, abortion is wrong.*

Gap / Assumption: *A foetus is an innocent person.*

The premise and conclusion share the word 'wrong,' but they are about different subjects: the premise is about persons, the conclusion is about abortion. The bridge is the assumption that abortion involves killing an innocent person — which itself requires the assumption that a foetus has the moral status of a person. The entire real-world debate about abortion centres on exactly this assumption. When people disagree about abortion, they rarely disagree about whether killing persons is wrong. They disagree about whether foetuses are persons. The assumption is the debate.

Argument 6 — The Reading Journal (Compound Argument)

This is a compound argument. It has one conclusion supported by multiple separate chains of reasoning. It was included to show that the structure of an argument can be complex without the underlying logic being any different.

Conclusion [1]: *Every CAT aspirant should keep a reading journal.*
Premise [2]: *A reading journal forces the student to articulate what a passage actually said,*
Premise [3]: *because writing a summary in your own words exposes the gaps in your understanding that silent reading hides.*
Premise [4]: *A reading journal builds a personal record of the kinds of passages a student finds difficult,*
Premise [5]: *which allows the student to spot patterns in her own weaknesses over weeks and months.*
Premise [6]: *A reading journal slows the student down in a test-prep culture that constantly pushes her to go faster.*

Every link in this chain has its own gap. From [3] to [2]: assumption that *articulating what a passage said is important for CAT preparation.* From [5] to [4]: assumption that *spotting patterns in one's weaknesses is important for improvement.* From [6] to [1]: assumption that *slowing down is a benefit rather than a liability in test preparation.* The compound argument does not make assumption questions harder — it just gives you more gaps to name. The method is identical: find the conclusion, find the premise at the relevant link, name the gap.

HOW TO SPOT THE GAP — THE THREE-STEP METHOD

The same three-step move applies on every Assumption question, regardless of how complex the argument looks.

Step 1: Find the conclusion

Ask: what is the author trying to establish? What is the main claim being made? Look for conclusion indicators: therefore, thus, hence, so, this means, this shows, as a result, it follows that, consequently. If there are no explicit indicators, ask: which sentence is everything else being used to support? That is your conclusion.

Step 2: Find the premises

Ask: what reasons has the author given to support the conclusion? Look for premise indicators: because, since, after all, given that, as, for, the reason is. These are the stated evidences. They are your starting point.

Step 3: Find the necessary support — name the gap

Now look at what must be true for the premises to logically lead to the conclusion. Ask: *what is the author taking for granted?* What must be true in order for this premise to produce this conclusion? The simplest formulation: if the argument is *A is B, therefore A is C*, then the assumption is *B is C*. That is the connecting link. Name it. Then evaluate the options against it.

The check before committing: apply the negation test. Take the option you think is the assumption. Negate it. If the conclusion is destroyed, the option is the assumption. If the argument merely becomes weaker, it is a strengthener. If negating it makes no difference, it is irrelevant.

THE QUESTIONS

Question 1 • *Assumption — CAT 2017 — IIM Lucknow — Creative Cities*

Source: CAT 2017, Paragraph 6 of the passage on creativity and inequality.

> Creativity (or the lack of it) follows the same general contours of the great socio-economic divide — our rising inequality — that plagues us. According to my own estimates, roughly a third of us across the United States, and perhaps as much as half of us in our most creative cities — are able to do work which engages our creative faculties to some extent, whether as artists, musicians, writers, techies, innovators, entrepreneurs, doctors, lawyers, journalists or educators — those of us who work with our minds. That leaves a group that I term "the other 66 percent," who toil in low-wage rote and rotten jobs — if they have jobs at all — in which their creativity is subjugated, ignored or wasted.

The author's conclusions about the most 'creative cities' in the US (paragraph 6) are based on his assumption that...

(1) people who work with their hands are not doing creative work.
(2) more than half the population works in non-creative jobs.
(3) only artists, musicians, writers, and so on should be valued in a society.
(4) most cities ignore or waste the creativity of low-wage workers.

Correct Answer: (1)

Type

Assumption. The stem is asking what the author must be taking as given in order for his claim about the most creative cities to hold. The phrase *based on his assumption that* is the marker.

The Demand

The question is anchored specifically to the conclusions about the *most creative cities* — not to the passage as a whole and not to the US data in general. Read that carefully. The author says that in the most creative cities, as much as half of the population does work that engages creative faculties — work done by artists, musicians, writers, techies, doctors, lawyers, and so on. He describes this group as 'those of us who work with our minds.' The implicit consequence is that the other half do not work with their minds and are therefore not engaged in creative work.

Anticipate

The argument's key move is to equate creativity with mind-work and to imply that those who do not work with their minds are not doing creative work. For the author's statistics about most creative cities to hold, he needs this definitional bridge to be true. The anticipated assumption: *those who do not work with their minds — those who work with their hands, in the physical-labour sense — are not engaged in creative work.*